

Schools of Buddhism (Buddha's paths for ending suffering)

COMPLETE MULTI-PAGE FLOWCHART COMPANION

Basic -> Optional Advanced -> Register Retrieval -> PYQ Routes & Answer Spine

Landscape visual edition | Source-complete learner-v2 | 21 August 2026

Reading rule: follow the vertical arrows. Each continuation card retains source-owned definitions, classifications, derivations, objections, replies, comparisons, traps and recall cues. Practice prose is not duplicated; only verified question routes and answer architecture are mapped.

TECHNICAL-TERM TRANSLATION GATEWAY

Every Sanskrit, Pali, Prakrit or Hindi technical expression used later is introduced here with its immediate exam-safe English meaning. Prominent visual maps repeat the translation so no diagram depends on untranslated labels.

Technical term (immediate English meaning)	Technical term (immediate English meaning)	Technical term (immediate English meaning)
āstika (Veda-affirming or orthodox school)	nāstika (Veda-rejecting or heterodox school)	ātman (enduring self or soul)
anātman (no permanent self)	anātmavāda (doctrine of no permanent self)	anīśvaravāda (denial of a creator God)
Īśvara (Lord or creator God)	karma (action and its morally consequential residue)	saṃsāra (cycle of rebirth and suffering)
mokṣa (liberation)	nirvāṇa (cessation of craving and conditioned suffering)	dharma (doctrine, duty or constitutive factor, as context requires)
adharma (non-duty or, in Jainism, the medium enabling rest)	pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge)	pramā (valid cognition)
pratyakṣa (perception)	anumāna (inference)	śabda (verbal testimony)
upamāna (comparison or analogy)	arthāpatti (postulation or presumption)	anupalabdhi (non-cognition used to know absence)
vyāpti (invariable concomitance)	upādhi (hidden limiting condition)	tarka (hypothetical or reductio reasoning)
anvaya (positive agreement in presence)	vyatireka (negative agreement in absence)	anvaya-vyatireka (joint method of agreement in presence and absence)
pūrvapakṣa (opponent's prima-facie position)	siddhānta (established conclusion)	śāstra (authoritative treatise or discipline)
sūtra (concise aphoristic text)	darśana (philosophical system or vision)	guṇa (quality)
dravya (substance)	paryāya (changing mode)	puruṣa (person or conscious principle)
prakṛti (primordial material nature)	manas (mind)	rūpa (material form)
vedanā (feeling)	saṃjñā (recognition or perception)	saṃskāra (mental formation or disposition)
vijñāna (consciousness)	avidyā (ignorance)	trṣṇā (craving)
upādāna (clinging or grasping)	jāti (birth)	jarā-maraṇa (ageing and death)
bija (causal seed or latent potency)	svabhāva (intrinsic own-nature)	sat (being or reality)
duḥkha (suffering or unsatisfactoriness)	ahiṃsā (non-violence)	apūrva (unseen ritual potency)
adrṣṭa (unseen causal force)	Mīmāṃsā (Vedic exegesis school)	Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology)
Vaiśeṣika (school of categories and atomism)	Sāṃkhya (dualistic enumeration school)	Vedānta (Upaniṣad-based end-of-the-Veda tradition)
Yogācāra (Buddhist consciousness-only school)	Mādhyamika (Buddhist middle-way emptiness school)	jīva (living soul or conscious being)

Technical term (immediate English meaning)	Technical term (immediate English meaning)	Technical term (immediate English meaning)
jñāna (knowledge)	Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)	Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika (combined realist traditions of logic and categories)
Sāṃkhya-Yoga (paired traditions of dualist enumeration and disciplined practice)	Vedāntic (relating to an Upaniṣad-based Vedānta tradition)	Upaniṣadic (relating to the philosophical Upaniṣads)
śruti (revealed Vedic scripture)	Naiyāyika (adherent of the Nyāya school)	pāramārthika (ultimate level)
arthakriyā (causal efficacy)	Śūnyavāda (emptiness doctrine)	anekānta (many-sidedness)
bhaṅga (predicative mode)	bhaṅgas (seven predicative modes)	nairātmya (absence of a permanent self)
Nyaya (school of logic and epistemology)	Vaisesika (school of categories and atomism)	Samkhya (dualistic enumeration school)
Vedanta (Upaniṣad-based end-of-the-Veda tradition)	Mimamsa (Vedic exegesis school)	Isvara (Lord or creator God)
atman (enduring self or soul)	moksa (liberation)	nirvana (cessation of craving and conditioned suffering)
Buddhism (Buddha's path for understanding and ending suffering)	pratītyasamutpāda (dependent origination)	kṣaṇikavāda (doctrine of momentariness)
nairātmyavāda (doctrine of no permanent self)	śūnyatā (emptiness of independent intrinsic nature)	nidāna (causal link)
nidānas (twelve causal links of dependent origination)	dvādaśa-nidāna (twelfefold chain of dependent origination)	nāma-rūpa (name-and-form or psycho-physical organism)
ṣaḍāyatana (six sense bases)	sparsa (contact)	bhava (becoming or karmically conditioned existence)
śāśvatavāda (eternalism)	ucchedavāda (annihilationism)	arthakriyākāritva (capacity to perform a causal function)
sahakārin (auxiliary causal condition)	santāna (causal continuum or stream)	santati (serial continuity)
vināśitvānumāna (inference from destructibility)	kṣaṇabhaṅga (momentary disintegration)	pratyabhijñā (recognition of something as the same)
sādṛśya (similarity)	pratisandhāna (continuity-linking connection)	ālaya-vijñāna (store-consciousness)
pudgala-nairātmya (no-self of the person)	dharma-nairātmya (no intrinsic self-nature in phenomena)	pañcaskandha (five aggregates)
pañcaskandhas (five aggregates)	Triratna (three jewels: Buddha, Dharma and Sangha)	Śīla (ethical discipline)
samādhi (meditative concentration)	prajñā (liberating wisdom)	pudgala (conventionally designated person)
Saṅgha (Buddhist community)	nibbāna (Pali term for nirvāṇa or cessation)	Vaibhāṣika (Buddhist direct-realist Abhidharma school)
Sautrāntika (Buddhist representational-realist school)	Vijñānavāda (consciousness-only doctrine)	vijñaptimātratā (cognition-only or representation-only)
tri-svabhāva (three natures of cognition)	parikalpita-svabhāva (imagined nature)	paratantra-svabhāva (dependent nature)
pariṇiṣpanna-svabhāva (perfected nature)	catuṣkoṭi (four-cornered logical analysis)	asti (it is)
nāsti (it is not)	naivāsti na nāsti (it neither is nor is not)	saṃvṛti-satya (conventional truth)
paramārtha-satya (ultimate truth)	prasajya-pratiṣedha (non-implicative negation)	paryudāsa-pratiṣedha (implicative negation)

Technical term (immediate English meaning)	Technical term (immediate English meaning)	Technical term (immediate English meaning)
prasaṅga (reductio consequence)	Prāsaṅgika (Mādhyamika method relying on reductio)	Svātantrika (Mādhyamika method using autonomous syllogisms)
svalakṣaṇa (unique momentary particular)	sāmānyalakṣaṇa (conceptually constructed general character)	apoha (exclusion of what is other)
kalpanāpoḍha (free from conceptual construction)	abhrānta (non-erroneous)	svasaṃvedana (reflexive self-awareness of cognition)
indriya-pratyakṣa (sense perception)	mānasa-pratyakṣa (mental perception)	yogi-pratyakṣa (yogic perception)
pramāṇaphala (result of valid cognition)	pramātr (knower)	avyākṛta (undeclared or unanswered metaphysical question)
avyākata (Pali term for an undeclared question)	Tathāgata (the Thus-Gone or Thus-Come Buddha)	arthasaṃhita (connected with practical benefit)
kṛtanāśa (loss of the result of an action already done)	akṛtābhyāgama (arrival of a result from an action not done)	asaṃskṛta (unconditioned)
āgama (authoritative teaching or scripture)	pratityasamutpada (dependent origination)	ksanikavada (doctrine of momentariness)
nairatmyavada (doctrine of no permanent self)	sunyata (emptiness of independent intrinsic nature)	skandha (aggregate constituting the person-process)
skandhas (five aggregates constituting the person-process)	alayavijnana (store-consciousness)	Mādhyamaka (middle-way emptiness tradition)
Mahāyāna (Great Vehicle Buddhist tradition)	Theravāda (Teaching of the Elders Buddhist tradition)	Sarvāstivāda (school teaching that dharmas exist across the three times)
Puggalavāda (Buddhist personalist school)	satkāryavāda (doctrine that the effect pre-exists in its cause)	ārambhavāda (doctrine that an effect is a genuinely new beginning)
śūnya (empty of independent intrinsic nature)	Hinayāna (older and now avoided label meaning Lesser Vehicle)	bāhya-pratyakṣa-vāda (doctrine that external objects are directly perceived)
bāhyānumeya-vāda (doctrine that external objects are inferred)	pudgala-ātman (substantial personal self)	rāga (attachment)
dveṣa (aversion)	pariṇāma (real transformation)	māyā (appearance or illusion)
mithyā (false or illusory)	śramaṇa (renunciant seeker)	Mūlamadhyamakakārikā (Root Verses on the Middle Way)
Vigrahavyāvartanī (Dispeller of Objections)	Milinda-pañha (Questions of King Milinda)	Cūḷamālukya-sutta (Short Discourse to Mālunkyaputta)
Two-pramāṇa (two-means-of-knowledge scheme)	paramārtha-sat (ultimately real)	saṃvṛti-sat (conventionally real)
sahakāri-anapekṣā (independence from auxiliary causes)	pariṇāmic (undergoing real transformation)	nirvāṇa-soteriology (theory of liberation through nirvāṇa)
pudgala-nairātmyavāda (doctrine of no-self of the person)	dharma-nairātmyavāda (doctrine that phenomena lack intrinsic self-nature)	vijñapti-mātra (cognition-only or representation-only)
dharmas (plural form: doctrine, duty or constitutive factor, as context requires)	pramāṇas (plural form: means of valid knowledge)	puruṣas (plural form: person or conscious principle)
bījas (plural form: causal seed or latent potency)	Triratnas (plural form: three jewels: Buddha, Dharma and Sangha)	

MASTER LEARNING SEQUENCE

01 0. ONE-SCREEN MAP	02 1. PRATĪTASAMUTPĀDA (dependent origination) (Pratityasamutpada (dependent origination)) — DEPENDENT ORIGATION
03 2. KṢAṆIKAVĀDA (doctrine of momentariness) (Ksanikavada (doctrine of momentariness)) — DOCTRINE OF MOMENTARINESS	04 3. NAIRĀTMYAVĀDA (doctrine of no permanent self) (Nairatmyavada (doctrine of no permanent self)) — NO-SELF DOCTRINE
05 4. THE FOUR SCHOOLS OF BUDDHISM (Buddha's path for understanding and ending suffering)	06 5. BUDDHIST ARGUMENTS AGAINST A CREATOR GOD
07 6. INTER-THINKER / INTER-SCHOOL DEBATES	08 7. CRITICISMS AND REPLIES — NAMED PŪRVAPAKṢA (opponent's prima-facie position)
09 8. COMMON UPSC TRAPS	10 9. KEYWORD & STATEMENT BANK
11 9A. BUDDHIST EPISTEMOLOGY — THE PRAMĀṆA (means of valid knowledge) SCHOOL (Dignāga, Dharmakīrti)	12 9B. AVYĀKATA (Pali term for an undeclared question) / AVYĀKṚTA (undeclared or unanswered metaphysical question) QUESTIONS — PRAGMATIC SILENCE
13 9C. PRESUPPOSITION LEDGER	14 9D. PŪRVAPAKṢA (opponent's prima-facie position)–SIDDHĀNTA (established conclusion) LEDGER

Read numbered cells left-to-right, then continue on the next row.

BASIC — COMPLETE TEACHING FLOW



Source-complete coverage ledger and answer-worthiness labels

Source corpus	Final location	Retention decision
Layered Simple/Core/Exam/Rapid material	Basic Learning Session	Complete eight-subtopic sequence retained
Layered Advanced material	Optional Advanced	Every advanced synthesis retained after practice
Canonical owner	Reconciled through layered session	Causation, impermanence, no-self, four schools, epistemology and liberation retained
Legacy solved workbook	PYQs and Answer Practice	All thirteen solved PYQs preserved and improved
Premium diagnostic replacement	MCQs / Remediation	Legacy 24+8 set expanded to genuine 40+8 with strict rotation
Original practice	PYQs and Answer Practice	Six solved non-PYQ models replace the legacy three-model set
Consolidated register	Final section	A–L retrieval framework covers the complete printed syllabus

Answer-worthiness. *Pratītyasamutpāda*, *kṣaṇikavāda*, *nairātmyavāda*, *nirvāṇa* and the four-school contrast are **CORE SYLLABUS**. Buddhist *pramāṇa* theory, *apoha*, *avyākṛta* questions and controlled cross-school objections are **CORE SUPPORTING DEPTH** where they sharpen PYQ answers. Heritage diplomacy is an application anchor, never doctrinal proof.



Contemporary-anchor discipline

FACT: **Fact:** The High Commission of India in Colombo reported the public exposition of the Devnimori Buddha relics at Gangaramaya Temple from 4–10 February 2026, presenting it as cultural and spiritual engagement through shared Buddhist heritage. CAUTION: **Inference:** The event can frame Buddhism as a living civilizational language, but answers must derive doctrine from dependent origination, momentariness, no-self, emptiness, consciousness and liberation.



Learner-v2 roadmap

SUFFERING HAS CONDITIONS
->
CONDITIONED THINGS ARE IMPERMANENT
->
NO PERMANENT SELF OWNS THE STREAM
->
SCHOOLS DISAGREE ABOUT EXTERNAL OBJECTS, CONSCIOUSNESS AND EMPTINESS
->
INSIGHT BREAKS CRAVING AND CONDITIONED SUFFERING
->
NIRVĀṆA (cessation of craving and conditioned suffering)



Master distinction gateway		
Doctrine	Central question	Exam-safe formulation
<i>Pratītyasamutpāda</i> (dependent origination)	How do suffering and phenomena arise?	through causes and conditions
<i>Kṣaṇikavāda</i> (doctrine of momentariness)	What is the temporal nature of the causally real?	causally efficacious reals are momentary
<i>Nairātmyavāda</i> (doctrine of no permanent self)	Is there an enduring owner of the stream?	no permanent self beyond the aggregates
<i>Śūnyatā</i> (emptiness of independent intrinsic nature)	Do dependently arisen things possess own-nature?	they are empty of independent <i>svabhāva</i> (intrinsic own-nature)

Master verdict: Buddhism is a family of anti-substantialist, causally ordered and soteriological systems; its schools range from realism through consciousness-only analysis to radical emptiness.



How to use this layered session

Each logical subtopic follows the Philosophy five-layer sequence:

Layer	Purpose
1. SIMPLE START	Plain-language visual gateway
2. CORE UPSC	Complete retained doctrine, arguments and examples
3. ADVANCED	Objections, replies, comparisons and refinements
4. EXAM APPLICATION	Verified PYQ routing and answer structure
5. RAPID REVISION	Traps, recall spines and mastery preparation

Source audit: the canonical Buddhism knowledge file and complete 2018-2025 PYQ bank were checked. Local OCR-searchable chapters in Chatterjee-Datta (Buddhist chapter beginning at file page 149) and C. D. Sharma (file pages 67-81) were directly inspected. The February 2026 Devnimori relic exposition was rechecked through the High Commission of India in Colombo and is used only as a contemporary conceptual anchor. Qdrant was not required.

Preservation note: every substantive section of the earlier complete session is retained. The new material adds simple gateways and explicit layers without replacing the original depth.



Plain-language visual - suffering is a process, not a fate

IGNORANCE
|
conditions craving and clinging
|
becoming, birth, ageing and death

Change the conditions -> change the result.

In simple words: Buddhism asks what keeps suffering happening. If suffering arises because conditions cooperate, it is neither eternal nor imposed by fate. Remove the sustaining conditions and the process can cease.

First idea	Easy meaning
Pratītyasamutpāda (dependent origination)	Things arise and cease through conditions
Twelve nidānas (twelve causal links of dependent origination)	Detailed cycle from ignorance to ageing and death
Middle way	Neither eternal substance nor sheer nothingness
Soteriological point	A conditioned problem can be interrupted

Memory line: because suffering is dependently produced, liberation is causally possible.



0. ONE-SCREEN MAP

FOUR NOBLE TRUTHS = existential frame
|
+- duḥkha (suffering or unsatisfactoriness) has a cause -> dependent origination (pratītyasamutpāda (dependent origination))
| |
| +- whatever arises dependently lacks self-existence (svabhāva (intrinsic own-nature))
| +- whatever is conditioned is impermanent
| +- what is called "person" is only a dependently arisen aggregate
|
+- KṢĀNIKAVĀDA (doctrine of momentariness): all conditioned reals are momentary
+- NAIRĀTMYAVĀDA (doctrine of no permanent self): no permanent ātman (enduring self or soul)/self
+- NIRVĀṆA (cessation of craving and conditioned suffering): cessation of the causal process of suffering

FOUR SCHOOLS
Vaibhāṣika (Buddhist direct-realist Abhidharma school) -> Sautrāntika (Buddhist representational-realist school) -> Yogācāra (Buddhist consciousness-only school)/Vijñānavāda (consciousness-only doctrine) -> Mādhyamika (Buddhist middle-way emptiness school)/Śūnyavāda (emptiness doctrine)
direct realism representationalism consciousness-only emptiness of svabhāva (intrinsic own-nature)

CAUTION: Exam key: In Buddhism, the three syllabus terms are not separate islands. Dependent origination yields impermanence; impermanence undermines substantial selfhood; no-self reshapes karma, rebirth and nirvāṇa.



1. PRATĪTYASAMUTPĀDA (dependent origination) (Pratītyasamutpada (dependent origination)) — DEPENDENT ORIGINATION

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Recommended opening definition: **pratītyasamutpāda (dependent origination) is the principle that phenomena arise and cease in dependence on conditions, rejecting both eternalism and causeless annihilationism.**



1.1 Statement

- FACT: **Pratītyasamutpāda** means dependent origination: whatever arises, arises depending on causes and conditions; whatever ceases, ceases when those conditions cease.
- FACT: The standard formula, in substance, is: "**imasmim sati idaṃ hoti; imass' uppādā idaṃ uppajjati; imasmim asati idaṃ na hoti; imassa nirodhā idaṃ nirujjhati**" — this being, that becomes; from the arising of this, that arises; this not being, that is not; from the cessation of this, that ceases.
- FACT: It is not merely a cosmological thesis. It is the key to the arising of **duḥkha** and therefore the key to its cessation.



1.2 The Four Noble Truths as the frame

- FACT: Buddhism states the problem first: **duḥkha**.
- FACT: It then identifies a causal structure: **duḥkha** has an origin.
- FACT: Because the origin is conditioned, it can cease.
- FACT: Therefore a path is possible.
- CAUTION: So dependent origination is the philosophical grammar of the Four Noble Truths. The first truth states the fact of suffering; the second gives its dependent arising; the third gives dependent cessation; the fourth is the practical discipline for breaking the chain.



1.3 The twelve nidānas (twelve causal links of dependent origination) in order

- FACT: The classical chain of dependent origination is expressed through the **dvādaśa-nidāna** sequence:
- **avidyā** — ignorance
- **saṃskāra** — formations/dispositions
- **vijñāna** — consciousness
- **nāma-rūpa** — name-and-form
- **ṣaḍāyatana** — six sense-bases
- **spārśa** — contact
- **vedanā** — feeling

- **trṣṇā** — craving

- **upādāna** — clinging/grasping

- **bhava** — becoming/existence

- **jāti** — birth

- **jarā-maraṇa** — old age and death

- FACT: In visual Buddhist pedagogy, this sequence is often represented through the **bhava-cakra** (wheel of becoming), showing how ignorance and craving keep cyclic existence in motion.



1.4 Argument structure

- FACT: What is experienced is not self-grounding; it occurs only in dependence.

- FACT: If a thing were self-existent by its own nature, it would not depend on conditions.

- FACT: But all conditioned phenomena arise and cease in dependence on conditions.

- FACT: Therefore conditioned phenomena are neither eternal substances nor sheer nothingness; they are dependent processes.

- CAUTION: The existential point is that suffering too is a process, not a metaphysical fate. Therefore it is removable.



1.5 Presupposition

- CAUTION: The doctrine presupposes that explanation should be sought through **conditional relations**, not through a static substratum like ātman or Brahman and not through a creator-God standing outside the chain.

- CAUTION: It also presupposes that what matters philosophically is not an absolutely first beginning but the structure by which bondage is maintained here and now.



1.6 Distinction: middle way between extremes

- FACT: Buddhism presents dependent origination as the **middle way** between:

- **śāśvatavāda** — eternalism: some enduring self/substance exists unchanged.

- **ucchedavāda** — annihilationism: things are sheer nullities or persons are simply obliterated without causal continuity.

- CAUTION: Why is this a middle? Because Buddhism denies permanent substance, yet it also denies that phenomena are sheer nothing. What exists does so dependently.



1.7 Example

- CAUTION: A flame persists only because wick, oil, oxygen and ignition remain coordinated. Remove the conditions and the flame ceases. Yet the flame is not absolutely unreal while it burns. This approximates dependent origination better than the language of substance.

**1.8 Objection**

- QUESTION: If everything depends on something else, does Buddhism explain nothing ultimately? Does it create an infinite regress of conditions?

**1.9 Reply**

- FACT: Buddhism need not posit an unconditioned substance to make conditioning intelligible. Its primary concern is soteriological: to show that suffering is conditioned and therefore stoppable.
- CAUTION: UPSC answers should stress that dependent origination is not a failed search for a first cause; it is a diagnosis of dependent becoming.

**1.10 How momentariness follows from dependent origination**

- FACT: What depends on conditions cannot remain numerically identical through all times, because it changes with the rise and fall of those conditions.
- FACT: Therefore what is conditioned is **anitya** (impermanent); Buddhist logicians radicalize this into **kṣaṇikavāda**, according to which what is real is momentary.
- CAUTION: Thus a 2019-style answer can move from pratītyasamutpāda to kṣaṇikavāda by arguing: the dependently arisen has no independent enduring essence; it is event-like, not substance-like.

**1.11 How 2024's "everything is void" and "everything is real" both arise from pratītyasamutpāda (dependent origination)****(a) Mādhyamika (Buddhist middle-way emptiness school): dependent origination implies emptiness**

- FACT: Nāgārjuna's central move is that what arises dependently cannot possess **svabhāva** (self-being/own-nature).
- FACT: Therefore all dharmas are **śūnya** — empty of independent essence.
- FACT: In substance, Nāgārjuna identifies dependent origination and emptiness: what is dependently arisen is what is called empty.
- CAUTION: This does **not** mean sheer non-being; it means lack of intrinsic, self-subsistent reality.

**(b) Vaibhāṣika (Buddhist direct-realist Abhidharma school) / Sautrāntika (Buddhist representational-realist school): dependent origination implies conditioned reality**

- FACT: The realist Buddhist schools agree that things arise dependently.
- FACT: But instead of inferring emptiness of all dharmas in the Mādhyamika sense, they say: precisely because things arise causally, they are **real as conditioned entities**.
- FACT: Vaibhāṣika treats dharmas as real and directly knowable; Sautrāntika treats them as real though not directly perceived externally.
- CAUTION: Thus the same causal thesis can support two ontological emphases: absence of self-nature, or reality of conditioned events.



(c) Distinguishing the two conclusions

School move	What is denied	What is affirmed
Mādhyamika (Buddhist middle-way emptiness school)	intrinsic nature (svabhāva (intrinsic own-nature))	conventional dependent existence
Vaibhāṣika (Buddhist direct-realist Abhidharma school) / Sautrāntika (Buddhist representational-realist school)	eternal substance and self	reality of conditioned dharmas (plural form: doctrine, duty or constitutive factor, as context requires)



1.12 Cessation and knowledge

- FACT: Ignorance of dependent origination is bondage; insight into it is release.
- CAUTION: Therefore the 2023 question — ignorance of dependent origination is suffering while its knowledge is cessation — should be answered not as a mere epistemic slogan, but as a claim that wrong metaphysical grasping fuels craving and hence suffering.



Exam route

- **2018 Q5(b), 10 marks:** derive *śūnyatā* from dependent origination without equating emptiness with non-being.
- **2019 Q7(c), 15 marks** and **2020 Q6(a), 20 marks:** show how dependence and causal change lead to momentariness.
- **2023 Q8(a), 20 marks:** connect ignorance of the chain to suffering and insight into the chain to cessation.
- **2024 Q6(b), 15 marks:** compare the realist and Mādhyamika conclusions from the same causal doctrine.



Rapid recall

- Standard pattern: this being, that arises; this ceasing, that ceases.
- Twelve links run from ignorance to ageing and death.
- *Pratītyasamutpāda* is causal, existential and soteriological.

- Middle way: causal continuity without permanent substance.
- Trap: dependent origination is not fatalism; conditions can be altered.



Plain-language visual - the flame is a stream of events

flame 1 -> flame 2 -> flame 3
similar and causally connected
but not one numerically unchanged flame

continuity = series, not permanent substance

In simple words: what looks like one lasting thing may be a rapidly connected sequence. Each moment performs its causal work and gives rise to the next.

Term	Easy meaning
Kṣaṇikavāda (doctrine of momentariness)	Conditioned reality is momentary
Arthakriyā (causal efficacy)	Capacity to produce an effect
Santāna (causal continuum or stream)	Causal continuum
Recognition	Similarity within a stream, according to Buddhism (Buddha's path for understanding and ending suffering)

Memory line: what is real acts; what acts does so in a changing causal moment.



2. KṢAṆIKAVĀDA (doctrine of momentariness) (Ksanikavada (doctrine of momentariness)) — DOCTRINE OF MOMENTARINESS

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Kṣaṇikavāda (doctrine of momentariness) holds that whatever is causally efficient exists only momentarily, because a permanent entity could neither change its causal power nor produce genuinely successive effects.



2.1 Statement

- FACT: Kṣaṇikavāda holds that whatever is real is momentary.
- FACT: A standard scholastic formulation runs in substance as: **whatever is truly real is momentary** (*sattve satyeva kṣaṇikatvam*).
- CAUTION: The doctrine is not that nothing exists; it is that reality is evental rather than substantial.



2.2 Argument from causal efficiency (arthakriyākāritva (capacity to perform a causal function))



Statement

- FACT: **Arthakriyākāritva** (causal efficacy / capacity to perform a function) is the Buddhist pramāṇa-school criterion of the real: **sat = arthakriyā-samartha** — the real is what is capable of producing an effect.
- FACT: **Kṣaṇikavāda** follows because whatever is causally effective must be moment-specific; a wholly permanent entity cannot explain why an effect appears now rather than always.
- CAUTION: This is the bridge between Buddhist epistemology and ontology: the same test that ranks **svalakṣaṇa** (unique particular) as ultimately real also grounds the thesis **yat sat tat kṣaṇikam** — whatever is real is momentary.



Argument

- FACT: To be real is to be causally efficacious; an entity that makes no difference is indistinguishable from a non-entity for Buddhist analysis.
- FACT: Causal efficacy must occur either **simultaneously** or **successively**.
- FACT: If a permanent entity produces its effect all at once, nothing remains for later production; this is the **yaugapadya** (simultaneity) horn.
- FACT: If it produces effects successively, then it functions differently at different moments; what functions differently is not wholly permanent. This is the **krāma** (succession) horn.
- FACT: If Nyāya says it acts only when auxiliary conditions (**sahakārin**, helper-conditions) are present, the Buddhist reply is the **sahakāri-anapekṣā** dilemma: either the permanent thing already has the power and does not need auxiliaries, or the decisive causal power lies in the changing auxiliaries rather than in the permanent thing.
- FACT: Therefore a permanent entity cannot coherently be causally efficient.
- FACT: Therefore whatever is real is momentary: **yat sat tat kṣaṇikam**.



Presupposition

- CAUTION: The argument presupposes a pragmatic-realist criterion: reality is not inert self-identity but effect-producing capacity.
- CAUTION: It also presupposes that a single unchanged entity cannot have genuinely different causal profiles at different times without ceasing to be unchanged.



Distinction		
Issue	FACT: Buddhist logician	FACT: Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika (combined realist traditions of logic and categories) opponent
Test of reality	FACT: causal efficacy (arthakriyā (causal efficacy))	FACT: substance, quality, action, universal, inherence and absence as categories
Enduring thing	FACT: only a conventional series	FACT: real substance enduring through changing qualities
Effect at different times	FACT: requires momentary causal phases	FACT: explained by auxiliary conditions acting on an enduring substance



Example

- CAUTION: A seed is real because it can issue in a sprout. But the seed that has exercised that precise sprout-producing capacity is no longer the same causal phase; the series has advanced.



Objection — Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology) (Vātsyāyana / Uddyotakara / Udayana line)

- FACT: Nyāya asks: why can a permanent substance not act at one time because relevant auxiliary conditions are then present?
- FACT: Nyāya also uses **pratyabhijñā** (recognition — “this is that same jar”), memory and moral desert to argue that enduring substances and selves are required.



Reply — Buddhist logicians

- FACT: The Buddhist reply is that if the permanent thing remains wholly unchanged, then the decisive factor lies elsewhere; its own efficacy is redundant.
- FACT: Recognition is explained through **sādrśya** (similarity) within a causal stream, not strict numerical identity.
- FACT: Memory and desert are explained through **santāna / santati** (causal continuum), with **ālaya-vijñāna** and **bīja** (seeds) supplying the Yogācāra version of the continuity device.
- CAUTION: The Nyāya rejoinder retains force: a mere series seems unable to own memories or deserts unless something owns the series.



2.3 Argument from destruction (vināśītvānumāna (inference from destructibility) / kṣaṇabhaṅga (momentary disintegration) line)

- FACT: Another line of reasoning holds that destruction does not require a second, separate destroyer added from outside.
- FACT: The very nature of the conditioned is to perish; arising already contains ceasing.
- CAUTION: Hence things are not first fully stable entities and later destroyed; their transience belongs to what they are.



2.4 Apparent continuity: santāna (causal continuum or stream)

- FACT: If everything is momentary, why does the world look continuous?
- FACT: Buddhism answers through **santāna** — a causal series or stream.
- FACT: Each moment gives rise to the next sufficiently similar moment, producing the appearance of persistence.
- FACT: Standard illustrations are a **flame** or a **stream**: continuity without strict identity.



2.5 Memory and personal identity under momentariness (2021)



Objection — Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology) (Vātsyāyana / Uddyotakara / Udayana line)

- FACT: If every mental state perishes instantly, then who remembers a past event?

- FACT: If the rememberer is numerically different from the experiencer, how can there be personal identity or moral responsibility?



Buddhist replies

- FACT: **Santāna**: memory belongs to the same causal stream, not to a permanent self.

- FACT: **Pratisandhāna**: reconnection/relinking explains continuity across moments and lives.

- FACT: **Ālaya-vijñāna** in Yogācāra: a store-consciousness carries latent impressions (**bija**, seeds), explaining the preservation of karmic and mnemonic potential.



Philosophical point

- CAUTION: The Buddhist answer is deliberately middle-path: the later subject is neither strictly the same nor wholly other than the earlier one.



2.6 Karma (action and its morally consequential residue) without a self (2022)



Problem

- FACT: Karma seems to require a persisting moral subject: the doer should receive the fruit.



Buddhist answer

- FACT: The stream receives the fruit of what the earlier stream-stage performed.

- FACT: The relation is **neither identity nor utter difference**.

- CAUTION: If it were strict identity, Buddhism would collapse into eternalism; if it were total difference, responsibility would collapse. The doctrine of series protects moral continuity without substantial selfhood.



2.7 Example

- CAUTION: One lamp lights another. The second flame is not numerically the first, yet it is causally connected to it. Rebirth and karmic fruition are often explained analogically in this way.



2.8 Objection — Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology) pratyabhijñā (recognition of something as the same) argument

- QUESTION: Recognition such as "this is the same person I met before" appears to require enduring identity, not merely stream-likeness.



2.9 Reply

- FACT: Buddhism can say recognition tracks practical continuity and similarity within a series, not metaphysical identity of a substance.
- CAUTION: The language of sameness belongs to conventional truth; ultimate analysis reveals only a flow of conditioned moments.



Exam route

- Reconstruct *arthakriyākāritva* before stating momentariness.
- Use the simultaneity/succession dilemma and address auxiliary conditions.
- **2021 Q7(b), 15 marks:** explain memory and identity through causal continuity, similarity and seeds, then concede the ownership objection.
- **2022 Q6(a), 20 marks:** apply the same stream model to karma and moral continuity.



Rapid recall

- Formula: whatever is real is momentary.
- Reality test: causal efficacy.
- Two horns for a permanent cause: simultaneous effects or changing succession.
- Continuity device: *santāna/santati*, not permanent identity.
- Trap: momentariness does not mean causal disconnectedness.



Plain-language visual - person as an organised process

BODY + FEELING + RECOGNITION
+ DISPOSITIONS + CONSCIOUSNESS
|
v
conventionally called "person"

No extra permanent owner is found.

In simple words: Buddhism does not deny everyday persons. It denies an additional unchanging self behind the five aggregates. The person is a dependently organised causal process.

Aggregate	Easy meaning
<i>Rūpa</i> (material form)	Material form
<i>Vedanā</i> (feeling)	Feeling
<i>Samjñā</i> (recognition or perception)	Recognition or designation
<i>Samskāra</i> (mental formation or disposition)	Dispositions and formations
<i>Vijñāna</i> (consciousness)	Consciousness

Memory line: conventional personhood remains; permanent substance-self is rejected.



3. NAIRĀTMYAVĀDA (doctrine of no permanent self) (Nairatmyavada (doctrine of no permanent self)) — NO-SELF DOCTRINE

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Nairātmyavāda (no-self doctrine) denies an eternal ātman (self) and explains the person as a dependently ordered continuum of five skandhas (aggregates), preserving conventional identity without a permanent substance.



3.1 Statement

- FACT: **Nairātmyavāda** or **anātmavāda** denies a permanent, unchanging ātman behind experience.
- FACT: What is conventionally called a person is only an aggregate of changing factors.



3.2 The five skandhas (five aggregates constituting the person-process)

- FACT: The person is analysed into five **skandhas**:

- **rūpa** — form/material body

- **vedanā** — feeling/sensation

- **saṃjñā** — perception/recognition

- **saṃskāra** — dispositions/formations

- **vijñāna** — consciousness

- CAUTION: The philosophical force of the doctrine lies in exhaustive analysis: if what we call self reduces to these aggregates and no extra owner is found, the self is a conceptual imputation, not an independently real substance.



3.3 Chariot analogy (Milinda-pañha (Questions of King Milinda))

- FACT: The classic **chariot analogy** argues that "chariot" is merely a name for the arrangement of axle, wheels, yoke and other parts.
- FACT: Likewise, "person" is a conventional designation for the aggregate of skandhas.
- CAUTION: The point is not that the person is uselessly unreal. It is that the person is conventionally valid but not ultimately self-subsistent.



3.4 Pudgala-nairātmya (no-self of the person) and dharma-nairātmya (no intrinsic self-nature in phenomena) (2021)



Pudgala-nairātmya (no-self of the person)

- FACT: Denial of a permanent personal self (**pudgala**, person).
- FACT: This is the minimum no-self thesis common to Buddhism.



Dharma-nairātmya (no intrinsic self-nature in phenomena)

- FACT: Denial that even dharmas possess intrinsic self-nature.
- FACT: This is developed most strongly in Mahāyāna, especially Mādhyamika.



School difference

- FACT: **Hīnayāna / early realist schools:** primarily affirm **pudgala-nairātmya**; dharmas are treated as real.
- FACT: **Mahāyāna:** affirms both **pudgala-nairātmya** and **dharma-nairātmya**; neither person nor dharma has svabhāva.



Distinction table

Thesis	What is denied	Who strongly stresses it
Pudgala-nairātmya (no-self of the person)	enduring person/self	all Buddhism (Buddha's path for understanding and ending suffering)
Dharma-nairātmya (no intrinsic self-nature in phenomena)	intrinsic nature of dharmas (plural form: doctrine, duty or constitutive factor, as context requires)	Mahāyāna (Great Vehicle Buddhist tradition), especially Mādhyamika (Buddhist middle-way emptiness school)



3.5 The Puggalavāda (Buddhist personalist school) foil

- FACT: Some Buddhist groups, often associated with the **Vātsīputriyas**, proposed a **pudgala** that is neither the same as nor different from the skandhas.
- FACT: Mainstream Buddhists criticized this as a relapse toward self-theory.

- CAUTION: In answers, use Puggalavāda as a foil: it shows that the pressure to preserve moral continuity was real, but orthodox Buddhist thought refused to answer it by reintroducing a substantial person.



3.6 Triratna (three jewels: Buddha, Dharma and Sangha) and no-self (2022)



Problem

- FACT: If there is no self, who takes refuge in the **Triratna** — Buddha, Dharma, Saṅgha?



Reply

- FACT: Buddhism can answer: the refuge-taker is the **conventional person**, a **prajñapti-puruṣa** or designated person, not an ultimately real soul.
- FACT: Ethical and spiritual practice proceeds at the level of conventional truth without requiring metaphysical ātman.
- CAUTION: Thus anātman does not abolish discipline; it purifies it of ego-metaphysics.



3.7 Nirvāṇa (cessation of craving and conditioned suffering)

- FACT: **Nirvāṇa** is the cessation of suffering and the extinguishing of the three fires: **rāga** (attachment), **dveṣa** (aversion), and **moha** (delusion).
- FACT: It is not best understood as a substantial place or eternal self-state gained by an entity.
- CAUTION: It is the cessation of the very process that produces bondage.



3.8 Is nirvāṇa (cessation of craving and conditioned suffering) consistent with kṣaṇikavāda (doctrine of momentariness) and nairātmyavāda (doctrine of no permanent self)? (2025)



Objection — Śaṅkara-type Advaita and Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology) realist

- FACT: If there is no self, who attains nirvāṇa?
- FACT: If everything is momentary, what persists in liberation?



Reply

- FACT: The question "who attains?" assumes the very self Buddhism rejects.

- FACT: Nirvāṇa is not an entity possessed by a soul.
- FACT: It is the cessation of craving, ignorance and the suffering-series grounded in them.
- CAUTION: So consonance exists: no-self removes the false claimant to liberation; momentariness explains why the chain can in fact cease.



Theravāda (Teaching of the Elders Buddhist tradition) and Mahāyāna (Great Vehicle Buddhist tradition) nuance

- FACT: **Theravāda**: emphasizes individual **nibbāna** and the arhat ideal.
- FACT: **Mahāyāna**: emphasizes the bodhisattva ideal and universal liberation.
- FACT: In Nāgārjuna's radical language, **saṃsāra and nirvāṇa are not two independent realms**; the difference lies in how dependent reality is grasped.



Exam route

- **2018 Q6(b), 15 marks** and **2025 Q8(c), 15 marks**: establish compatibility by distinguishing cessation of process from destruction of a permanent self.
- **2020 Q7(b), 15 marks**: use the five aggregates and chariot analogy, then define liberation without importing Vedānta.
- **2021 Q5(d), 10 marks**: distinguish personal no-self from Mahāyāna's no-self of dharmas.
- **2022 Q7(b), 15 marks**: explain how the three jewels guide a path without presupposing an eternal practitioner.



Rapid recall

- Five aggregates, no sixth permanent owner.
- *Pudgala-nairātmya*: no substantial person.
- *Dharma-nairātmya*: no intrinsic nature in dharmas.
- Karma continues through a causal stream.
- Nirvāṇa is cessation without an eternal possessor.



Plain-language visual - four answers to what is ultimately real

VAIBHASIKA : external dharmas (plural form: doctrine, duty or constitutive factor, as context requires) directly known
 SAUTRANTIKA : external dharmas (plural form: doctrine, duty or constitutive factor, as context requires) inferred from representations
 YOGACARA : cognitive process, not independent external object
 MADHYAMIKA : no dharma (doctrine, duty or constitutive factor, as context requires) has intrinsic self-nature

In simple words: the schools share impermanence and no-self but disagree about external objects, consciousness and the ultimate status of dharmas.

School	Recall label
Vaibhāṣika (Buddhist direct-realist Abhidharma school)	Direct realism
Sautrāntika (Buddhist representational-realist school)	Representational or inferential realism
Yogācāra (Buddhist consciousness-only school)	Consciousness-only analysis
Mādhyamika (Buddhist middle-way emptiness school)	Emptiness of intrinsic nature

Memory line: direct object -> inferred object -> cognition-only -> emptiness of every fixed position.



4. THE FOUR SCHOOLS OF BUDDHISM (Buddha's path for understanding and ending suffering)

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The four-school debate moves from Vaibhāṣika (Abhidharma realist school) and Sautrāntika (Sūtra-based representationalist school) to Yogācāra (yoga-practice consciousness-centred school) and Mādhyamika (Middle Way emptiness school), progressively questioning what can count as ultimately real.



4.1 Vaibhāṣika (Buddhist direct-realist Abhidharma school)

- FACT: Usually associated with Sarvāstivāda realism.
- FACT: Holds bāhya-pratyakṣa-vāda: external objects are directly perceived.
- FACT: Affirms sarvam asti in the technical sense that dharmas of past, present and future have some mode of existence.



Philosophical significance

- CAUTION: Vaibhāṣika preserves Buddhist anti-self doctrine while still maintaining a robust realism about dharmas.
- CAUTION: It is therefore a useful contrast both to Yogācāra idealism and to Mādhyamika anti-essentialism.



4.2 Sautrāntika (Buddhist representational-realist school)

- FACT: Holds bāhyānumeya-vāda: external objects exist, but are known only inferentially through mental representations.
- FACT: Rejects the Sarvāstivāda thesis that past and future dharmas exist in the same sense as present ones.

• FACT: Strongly privileges the present moment.



Distinction from Vaibhāṣika (Buddhist direct-realist Abhidharma school)

Issue	Vaibhāṣika (Buddhist direct-realist Abhidharma school)	Sautrāntika (Buddhist representational-realist school)
External object	real	real
How known	directly perceived	inferentially known via representation
Temporal ontology	past-present-future dharmas (plural form: doctrine, duty or constitutive factor, as context requires) exist	only present dharmas (plural form: doctrine, duty or constitutive factor, as context requires) fully exist



4.3 Yogācāra (Buddhist consciousness-only school) / Vijñānavāda (consciousness-only doctrine)



Statement

• FACT: Yogācāra advances **vijñaptimātra** or consciousness-only.

• FACT: What appears as external object is inseparable from modes of consciousness.



Key doctrine: ālaya-vijñāna (store-consciousness)

• FACT: The **ālaya-vijñāna** (store-consciousness) preserves karmic seeds (**bījas**), explaining continuity, memory and rebirth without a permanent self.



Arguments against external realism

• FACT: **Dream argument**: dream-objects are vividly experienced despite lacking corresponding external objects; therefore experienced objecthood does not prove external independent matter.

• FACT: **Atom critique**: if atoms are partless, they cannot combine spatially; if they have parts, they are not ultimate atoms. Hence external atomism is unstable.



Tri-svabhāva (three natures of cognition) (three natures)

• FACT: **parikalpita-svabhāva** — imagined nature

• FACT: **paratantra-svabhāva** — dependent nature

• FACT: **pariniṣpanna-svabhāva** — perfected/consummate nature

• CAUTION: These explain how deluded objectification arises and how it is overcome.



4.4 Mādhyamika (Buddhist middle-way emptiness school) / Śūnyavāda (emptiness doctrine)



Statement

- FACT: Associated especially with **Nāgārjuna**.
- FACT: The central thesis is **śūnyatā** (emptiness): absence of **svabhāva** (intrinsic nature / own-being), not sheer nothingness.
- FACT: In substance, Nāgārjuna identifies dependent origination and emptiness: what is dependently arisen is empty of independent essence.



Catuṣkoṭi (four-cornered logical analysis) — the four corners

Corner	Sanskrit	FACT: Basic claim
1	asti (it is)	FACT: It is.
2	nāsti (it is not)	FACT: It is not.
3	asti (it is) ca nāsti (it is not) ca	FACT: It both is and is not.
4	naivāsti naiva nāsti (it is not)	FACT: It neither is nor is not.

- FACT: **Early / Nikāya use**: the avyākata / avyākṛta questions are often framed through four alternatives, and all four are set aside because they do not conduce to liberation and rest on misleading presuppositions.
- FACT: **Madhyamaka use**: Nāgārjuna negates all four alternatives when they are applied to things imagined as possessing **svabhāva**.
- CAUTION: Thus the early use is primarily therapeutic and soteriological; the Madhyamaka use is also logical-ontological, because it exposes the incoherence of intrinsic nature.



Crucial logical nuance — why this is not simple contradiction

- FACT: Madhyamaka negation is best read as **prasajya-pratiṣedha** (non-implicative / commitment-free negation), not **paryudāsa-pratiṣedha** (implicative negation that asserts a positive alternative).
- FACT: The four corners are denied **of things taken as having svabhāva**; once svabhāva is dropped, the denial does not install a fifth positive thesis.
- FACT: Hence Nāgārjuna can claim, in the spirit of the *Vigrahavyāvartanī*, that he has no independent **pratijñā** (thesis) of his own.
- CAUTION: This means: "I deny that x has intrinsic nature" is not meant to assert a new metaphysical substrate called emptiness.



Two truths as the anti-nihilist frame

Truth	FACT: Meaning	CAUTION: Exam use
saṃvṛti-satya (conventional truth)	FACT: Conventional truth: language, persons, karma (action and its morally consequential residue), compassion and practice function dependently.	CAUTION: Prevents Madhyamaka from abolishing ordinary discourse.
paramārtha-satya (ultimate truth)	FACT: Ultimate truth: no dharma (doctrine, duty or constitutive factor, as context requires) possesses svabhāva (intrinsic own-nature).	CAUTION: Prevents conventional truth from being mistaken for substance.

- FACT: Conventional truth is not mere falsehood; it is the domain within which practical life and Buddhist discipline function.
- FACT: Ultimate truth is insight into the emptiness of all reified positions.
- FACT: Nāgārjuna warns that emptiness wrongly grasped destroys the dull-witted, like a snake wrongly seized.
- CAUTION: The two-truths doctrine keeps catuṣkoṭi from collapsing into nihilism: conventional functioning is preserved, ultimate intrinsic being is denied.



Objection — Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology) / Uddyotakara-type and modern irrationalism charge

- FACT: The opponent says: if all four alternatives are denied, the Mādhyamika either says nothing or contradicts himself.
- FACT: The opponent adds: the denial itself is a thesis, so the claim “I have no thesis” is self-refuting.



Reply — Nāgārjuna and later Madhyamaka

- FACT: Nāgārjuna's reply is the “my words are empty too” move: his statements do not possess svabhāva and therefore do not create a positive ontological commitment.
- FACT: The traditional image is that one magically created person (nirmītaka) may counteract another magically created person; similarly, empty words may cure empty reifications.
- FACT: The Mādhyamika uses arguments as medicine, not as a new metaphysical substance.
- CAUTION: Whether this reply fully succeeds is genuinely debated.
- QUESTION: The **Prāsaṅgika / Svātantrika** split marks this debate internally: **Candrakīrti** is associated with using reductio (**prasaṅga**) without independent syllogisms, while **Bhāvaviveka** allows independent (**svatantra**) inferences in debate.



Śūnyatā (emptiness of independent intrinsic nature) is not nihilism

- FACT: To say things are empty is to say they lack **svabhāva**.
- FACT: It is not to say they are absent in every sense.
- FACT: Since conventional truth remains operative, compassion, karma and the path are not denied.
- CAUTION: Emptiness undercuts metaphysical grasping, not dependent functioning.



5. BUDDHIST ARGUMENTS AGAINST A CREATOR GOD

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The Buddhist critique holds that a permanent and perfect creator cannot intelligibly initiate changing effects, acquire a new will, or remain morally insulated from the suffering attributed to creation.

CAUTION: This is a cross-paper theme and should be linked with Proofs for God and Religion without God.



5.1 Core lines of criticism

- FACT: If God is eternal and unchanging, genuine creation becomes difficult to explain, because willing or producing seems to involve change.
- FACT: If God creates from desire or purpose, that suggests lack, preference or incompleteness.
- FACT: The presence of suffering and evil sits uneasily with an omnipotent benevolent creator.
- FACT: Dependent origination already explains the arising of phenomena through conditions, making a creator unnecessary.



5.2 Philosophical force

- CAUTION: Buddhist critique is not mere atheistic denial; it is a systematic refusal of explanatory surplus. If conditioned arising explains the world-process, God is not needed.



Exam route

- **2019 Q5(b), 10 marks:** explain Yogācāra's denial of independently external objects using representations, dreams, seeds and the three natures.
- **2024 Q6(b), 15 marks:** contrast realist dharmas with Mādhyamika emptiness while preserving their shared causal starting point.
- Use a four-school matrix rather than four disconnected paragraphs.
- Never write "Yogācāra = Advaita" or "Mādhyamika = nihilism".



Rapid recall

- Vaibhāṣika: direct external realism.
- Sautrāntika: external cause inferred from representation.
- Yogācāra: *ālaya-vijñāna*, seeds and three natures.
- Mādhyamika: *śūnyatā*, two truths, *catuṣkoṭi*.

• No creator is required because conditioned causation performs the explanatory work.



Plain-language visual - where rivals apply pressure

NYAYA (school of logic and epistemology) -> memory and recognition need an enduring self
MIMAMSA (Vedic exegesis school) -> knowledge and universals need stable bearers
ADVAITA -> liberation is unintelligible without reality/self
CARVAKA -> no-self is bodily reduction
BUDDHISM (Buddha's path for understanding and ending suffering) -> causal continuity replaces permanent substance

In simple words: Buddhist process theory solves some problems created by substance, but rivals ask whether a process can remember, act, deserve consequences and attain liberation without an owner.

Memory line: every debate turns on whether causal continuity can perform the work of identity.



6. INTER-THINKER / INTER-SCHOOL DEBATES

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Buddhist schools share dependent origination and no-self but disagree over external objects, consciousness and ultimate truth; comparison must therefore preserve both their common therapeutic framework and their distinct ontologies.

Debate axis	Buddhist position	Rival / internal contrast
Causation	dependent origination	Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology)'s ārambhavāda (doctrine that an effect is a genuinely new beginning); Sāṃkhya (dualistic enumeration school)'s satkāryavāda (doctrine that the effect pre-exists in its cause)
Persistence	momentary stream	Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology) substance with changing qualities
Self	no permanent ātman (enduring self or soul)	Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology), Vedānta (Upaniṣad-based end-of-the-Veda tradition), Jainism affirm self/jīva (living soul or conscious being)
External world	varies by school	Vaibhāṣika (Buddhist direct-realist Abhidharma school) realism, Yogācāra (Buddhist consciousness-only school) idealism, Mādhyamika (Buddhist middle-way emptiness school) anti-essentialism
Nirvāṇa (cessation of craving and conditioned suffering)	cessation of duḥkha-process	Vedāntic (relating to an Upaniṣad-based Vedānta tradition) mokṣa (liberation) as self-realization
God	unnecessary / philosophically problematic	Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology) theism



6.1 Carvāka's rejection of self vs Buddhist rejection of ātman (enduring self or soul) (2024)

- FACT: **Carvāka** denies self beyond body and tends toward materialist reduction.
- FACT: **Buddhism** denies permanent self but does not reduce personhood simply to gross body; it analyses the person into skandhas and preserves karmic continuity without substance.

• CAUTION: Therefore both reject an eternal ātman, but for very different reasons and with very different moral-metaphysical consequences.



6.2 Internal Buddhist pūrvapakṣa (opponent's prima-facie position) chain — how the four schools answer one another

Stage	FACT: Siddhānta (established conclusion) claimed	CAUTION: Becomes pūrvapakṣa (opponent's prima-facie position) for	FACT: Next Buddhist reply
Vaibhāṣika (Buddhist direct-realist Abhidharma school) / Sarvāstivāda (school teaching that dharmas exist across the three times)	FACT: Dharmas (plural form: doctrine, duty or constitutive factor, as context requires) are real and, in the Sarvāstivāda (school teaching that dharmas exist across the three times) sense, have existence across past, present and future.	CAUTION: Sautrāntika (Buddhist representational-realist school) objects that this weakens momentariness and overpopulates ontology.	FACT: Only the present moment is fully operative; external objects are inferred through representations.
Sautrāntika (Buddhist representational-realist school)	FACT: External objects exist but are known inferentially, not directly.	CAUTION: Yogācāra (Buddhist consciousness-only school) objects that an inferred external object is unnecessary because all that is given is cognition.	FACT: Vijñapti-mātra (cognition-only or representation-only) (representation-only): objecthood is inseparable from consciousness-appearance.
Yogācāra (Buddhist consciousness-only school)	FACT: Consciousness-only explains appearance, karma (action and its morally consequential residue) and continuity through ālaya-vijñāna (store-consciousness) .	CAUTION: Madhyamaka objects that consciousness is being reified as a subtle substance.	FACT: Even consciousness lacks svabhāva (intrinsic own-nature) ; all dharmas (plural form: doctrine, duty or constitutive factor, as context requires) are empty.
Madhyamaka	FACT: Śūnyatā (emptiness of independent intrinsic nature) prevents every reification, including reification of emptiness.	CAUTION: Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology), Mīmāṃsā (Vedic exegesis school) and Advaita object that this risks nihilism or self-refutation.	FACT: Two truths preserve conventional practice while ultimate analysis denies intrinsic nature.

• CAUTION: **Exam payoff:** for “Schools of Buddhism”, do not list four schools mechanically. Present them as an argumentative escalation: realism of dharmas -> presentist representationalism -> idealist consciousness-only -> anti-essentialist emptiness.



7. CRITICISMS AND REPLIES — NAMED PŪRVAPAKṢA (opponent's prima-facie position)

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The central realist criticism is that momentariness and no-self cannot explain recognition, memory and moral responsibility; the Buddhist reply relocates continuity from substance to causally connected santāna (continuum).



7.1 Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology) criticism: memory, recognition and moral desert require a permanent self

Objection — Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology) (Vātsyāyana / Uddyotakara / Udayana line)

- FACT: **Pratyabhijñā** (recognition) — “this is that same jar” or “I am the same person who saw before” — appears to disclose identity through time.
- FACT: Memory seems to require that the subject who remembers be identical with the subject who experienced.
- FACT: Moral desert seems to require an enduring agent: the doer of an act must be the enjoyer or sufferer of its fruit.



Reply — Buddhist schools

- FACT: **Santāna / santati** (causal series) explains continuity without an identical substance.
- FACT: **Sādrśya** (similarity) explains why recognition mistakes a later similar causal phase for the numerically same object.
- FACT: The flame and river examples show continuity without strict identity: a later flame or river-stage is neither wholly the same nor wholly other.
- FACT: Yogācāra adds **ālaya-vijñāna** (store-consciousness) and **bija** (seeds) as the carrier of karmic and mnemonic potential without accepting an ātman.
- CAUTION: Nyāya's residual force: a series may explain causal succession, but it is less clear how a series can "own" memories unless some subject owns the series.



7.2 Kumārila Bhaṭṭa and Mīmāṃsā (Vedic exegesis school) criticism: pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge) supports self and universals



Objection — Kumārila Bhaṭṭa

- FACT: Mīmāṃsā defends a persisting self as the subject of cognition, duty, memory and Vedic action.
- FACT: Kumārila also resists **apoha** by arguing that general words and recognition require positive universals, not merely exclusion.
- FACT: A merely negative meaning such as "not-non-cow" seems unable to explain the positive cognition "cow".



Reply — Buddhist pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge) school

- FACT: Dignāga and Dharmakīrti reduce the self to a constructed unity imposed on a stream of momentary cognitions.
- FACT: Apoha explains generality as exclusion grounded in causal convergence: many distinct particulars produce the same practical judgment and action, so a concept is formed without a real universal.
- CAUTION: Residual force remains: critics argue that the exclusion must already know what to exclude, making apoha circular.



7.3 Śaṅkara / Advaita criticism: momentariness and emptiness make liberation unintelligible



Objection — Śaṅkara-type Advaita

- FACT: If everything is momentary, bondage and liberation cannot belong to one continuing subject.
- FACT: If there is no self, the unity of the knower is unintelligible.
- FACT: If **śūnyatā** is ultimate, the very denial seems to presuppose a self-luminous witnessing consciousness that makes denial possible.



Reply — Buddhist two-truths response

- FACT: Buddhism denies that liberation requires an eternal witness; liberation is the cessation of ignorance, craving and appropriation in a causal stream.
- FACT: At **saṃvṛti-satya** (conventional truth), persons, practice and compassion are valid designations.
- FACT: At **paramārtha-satya** (ultimate truth), neither person nor witness has intrinsic nature.
- CAUTION: The Advaitin's residual force is that Buddhist analysis must explain the unity of experience without quietly importing a witness.



7.4 Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology) / realist criticism: emptiness collapses into nihilism



Objection — Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology) and common realist charge

- FACT: If all dharmas are empty, nothing seems to remain for knowledge, ethics or liberation.
- FACT: If the Mādhyamika denies all theses, the denial appears self-refuting.



Reply — Madhyamaka

- FACT: Emptiness means emptiness of own-being, not absence of dependent functioning.
- FACT: The two truths preserve conventional causation, karma and path-practice while denying intrinsic nature.
- FACT: Nāgārjuna's "empty words" strategy treats philosophical utterance as a therapeutic instrument rather than a final ontology.
- CAUTION: Residual force remains in the debate over whether non-implicative negation can avoid becoming a thesis.



7.5 Criticism: karma (action and its morally consequential residue) without self is unjust



Objection — Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology), Mīmāṃsā (Vedic exegesis school) and Vedānta (Upaniṣad-based end-of-the-Veda tradition)

- FACT: If doer and enjoyer are not strictly identical, moral desert appears to disappear.
- FACT: If they are strictly different, punishment or reward would fall on another.



Reply — Buddhist middle position

- FACT: Buddhism rejects both strict identity and strict difference.
- FACT: The stream that receives the fruit is causally continuous with the stream-stage that acted.
- FACT: This avoids eternalism while preserving moral responsibility at the conventional level.
- CAUTION: The unresolved pressure is whether causal continuity alone is enough for desert, rather than merely for causal explanation.



Exam route

Use a dialectic grid: **named opponent** -> **exact target** -> **Buddhist reply** -> **residual pressure**.

For memory, karma and liberation questions, never answer with the word *santāna* alone. Explain causal transmission, similarity, seeds or store-consciousness, then assess whether transmission adequately supplies ownership.



Rapid recall

- Nyāya: recognition, memory and desert.
- Mīmāṃsā: positive universals and stable cognition.
- Advaita: subject and liberation.
- Buddhist reply: continuity without identity.
- Residual problem: a stream may transmit effects yet still seem to lack an owner.



Plain-language visual - four equations to avoid

NO-SELF != no conventional person
 EMPTINESS != nothing exists
 MOMENTARINESS != causal chaos
 NIRVANA (cessation of craving and conditioned suffering) != immortal ego or simple annihilation

In simple words: most weak answers fail through category errors rather than missing facts. Define what a doctrine denies and what it still preserves.

Memory line: Buddhism removes intrinsic substance while retaining conditioned function.



8. COMMON UPSC TRAPS

- CAUTION: **Trap 1:** treating pratīyasamutpāda as a simple linear cosmology. It is primarily a doctrine of dependent suffering and cessation.

- CAUTION: **Trap 2:** saying momentariness means non-existence. Buddhism says the real conditioned is momentary, not unreal in every sense.
- CAUTION: **Trap 3:** confusing **pudgala-nairātmya** with **dharma-nairātmya**.
- CAUTION: **Trap 4:** writing that all Buddhist schools say the same thing about the external world. They do not.
- CAUTION: **Trap 5:** calling śūnyatā nihilism. Mādhyamika explicitly resists that reading.
- CAUTION: **Trap 6:** saying Triratna is inconsistent with no-self because "nobody remains to practise." Buddhism admits a conventional person.
- CAUTION: **Trap 7:** answering karma-under-momentariness by smuggling in a hidden soul. The correct device is **santāna**, not ātman.
- CAUTION: **Trap 8:** treating catuṣkoṭi as a denial of logic. The Madhyamaka point is non-implicative negation of svabhāva, not casual contradiction.
- CAUTION: **Trap 9:** writing that Buddhist pramāṇa theory is just Nyāya logic with fewer pramāṇas. It rests on momentary particulars, apoha and no enduring knower.
- CAUTION: **Trap 10:** confusing Jain non-absolutism with Buddhist no-substance. Jainism preserves jīva and dravya; Buddhism denies self-substance.



9. KEYWORD & STATEMENT BANK

- FACT: **Pratītyasamutpāda:** dependent origination; this being, that becomes.
- FACT: **Dvādaśa-nidāna:** twelve links of conditioned becoming.
- FACT: **Kṣaṇikavāda:** whatever is real is momentary.
- FACT: **Arthakriyākāritva:** reality as causal efficiency.
- FACT: **Santāna:** causal stream/continuum.
- FACT: **Nairātmyavāda / anātman:** denial of permanent self.
- FACT: **Skandhas:** rūpa, vedanā, saṃjñā, saṃskāra, vijñāna.
- FACT: **Pudgala-nairātmya:** no personal self.
- FACT: **Dharma-nairātmya:** no self-nature in dharmas.
- FACT: **Vijñaptimātra:** consciousness-only.
- FACT: **Ālaya-vijñāna:** store-consciousness carrying seeds.
- FACT: **Śūnyatā:** emptiness of svabhāva.
- FACT: **Samvṛti / paramārtha:** conventional / ultimate truth.

- FACT: **Avyākata / avyākṛta**: undeclared questions set aside as non-conducive and presuppositionally defective.
- FACT: **Catuṣkoṭi**: four alternatives — is, is-not, both, neither — denied when applied to svabhāva.
- FACT: **Pramāṇa**: valid means of knowledge; Buddhist epistemologists reduce these to perception and inference.
- FACT: **Pratyakṣa / anumāna**: perception of unique particular / inference of conceptual general character.
- FACT: **Svalakṣaṇa / sāmānyalakṣaṇa**: unique causal particular / constructed general character.
- FACT: **Kalpanāpoḍha / abhrānta**: non-conceptual and non-erroneous perception.
- FACT: **Apoha**: exclusion theory of meaning; “cow” functions as “not-non-cow”.
- FACT: **Svasaṃvedana**: self-awareness of cognition, attacked by Nyāya and central to Buddhist epistemology.
- FACT: **Pramāṇaphala**: resultant cognition, treated by Dignāga as non-different from the pramāṇa-event.



Quick examinable statements

- CAUTION: “Ignorance of dependent origination is bondage because it converts process into substance and thereby fuels craving.”
- CAUTION: “Buddhist momentariness is not chaos but ordered succession.”
- CAUTION: “The person is neither an illusion in the trivial sense nor an ultimate self; it is a valid conventional designation.”
- CAUTION: “Śūnyatā denies intrinsic being, not dependent functioning.”

<!-- restored-2018-2020-doctrine:start -->



RESTORED 2018/2020 DOCTRINE DOSSIER



Pañcaskandhas (five aggregates), no-self and liberation

- FACT: The person is conventionally designated upon form, feeling, perception, formations and consciousness; none is permanent, autonomous or fit to be owned as “this is mine, this I am”.
- FACT: **Argument**: exhaustive analysis finds only conditioned aggregates; their causal dependence explains continuity without a separate ātman. Liberation is cessation of ignorance, craving and appropriation, not the release of a soul-substance.
- CAUTION: **Distinction**: no-self denies intrinsic personal substance, not causal continuity or conventional agency.



Dependent origination, momentariness and emptiness

- FACT: Kṣaṇikavāda radicalises conditioned arising: what depends on causes cannot possess unchanging efficacy. Madhyamaka draws the anti-essentialist conclusion that dependently originated things are empty of svabhāva.
- QUESTION: **Objection** -> **reply**: emptiness seems self-defeating or nihilistic. Nāgārjuna's reply is that emptiness itself is dependent designation and preserves conventional causation rather than abolishing it.

<!-- restored-2018-2020-doctrine:end -->

<!-- expanded-pyq-depth:start -->



CORPUS-DRIVEN DEPTH DELTA (complete 2018–2025 audit)

- CAUTION: **Priority**: Primary ownership rises to 13 of 112 parts and occurs in every year.
- FACT: **Required doctrinal depth**: The restored years add the Madhyamaka derivation of śūnyatā from dependent origination, no-self with nirvāṇa, kṣaṇikavāda as a derivative of dependent origination and the pañcaskandha account of personhood/liberation.
- ☐ **Trap / answer consequence**: Do not identify śūnyatā with non-existence or infer that causal continuity requires a soul; distinguish conventional designation from intrinsic nature.

<!-- expanded-pyq-depth:end -->



Exam route

Before writing, perform a four-part check:

- Have I defined the technical term?
- Have I shown its internal derivation?
- Have I stated what it does **not** mean?
- Have I linked it to suffering or liberation?

Use the retained keyword bank and doctrine dossier as the factual checklist for all 13 verified PYQs.



Rapid recall

- Empty = empty of intrinsic nature.
- No-self = no permanent substance-self.

- Momentary = causally connected momentary events.
- Two truths = conventional operation and ultimate non-intrinsic status.
- Trap: do not call every Buddhist school idealist or nihilist.



Plain-language visual - two ways of knowing

PERCEPTION -> unique causal particular, before conceptual construction
INFERENCE -> conceptual and linguistic judgement

Words classify by excluding what the object is not.

In simple words: Dignāga and Dharmakīrti accept perception and inference as the two fundamental knowledge sources. Perception encounters a unique particular; concepts and words organise experience indirectly.

Term	Easy meaning
<i>Svalakṣaṇa (unique momentary particular)</i>	Unique causal particular
<i>Sāmānyalakṣaṇa (conceptually constructed general character)</i>	Conceptual general character
<i>Apoha (exclusion of what is other)</i>	Meaning through exclusion of alternatives
<i>Pramāṇaphala (result of valid cognition)</i>	Result of valid cognition

Memory line: perception presents the particular; inference and language construct usable classifications.



9A. BUDDHIST EPISTEMOLOGY — THE PRAMĀṆA (means of valid knowledge) SCHOOL (Dignāga, Dharmakīrti)

CAUTION: Why this matters for UPSC: Buddhist epistemology is not an isolated logic chapter. It translates *nairātmyavāda* and *kṣaṇikavāda* into a theory of knowledge, language and debate.



9A.1 Two-pramāṇa (two-means-of-knowledge scheme) thesis



Statement

- FACT: Dignāga and Dharmakīrti accept only two independent **pramāṇas** (means of valid knowledge): **pratyakṣa** (perception) and **anumāna** (inference).
- FACT: Other candidates — **upamāna** (comparison), **arthāpatti** (postulation), **anupalabdhi** (non-apprehension) and **śabda** (testimony) — are reduced to inference or to perception-plus-inference.



Argument

- FACT: A pramāṇa must be individuated by the kind of object it reveals.
- FACT: There are exactly two object-types: **svalakṣaṇa** (unique particular / self-characterised particular) and **sāmānyalakṣaṇa** (general character / constructed universal-aspect).
- FACT: Perception grasps the **svalakṣaṇa**.
- FACT: Inference grasps the **sāmānyalakṣaṇa**.
- FACT: Therefore there are exactly two pramāṇas.



- Presupposition**
- CAUTION: The number of knowledge-sources is fixed by the object-side, not by a mere list of human cognitive habits.
 - CAUTION: There is no third kind of object beyond the unique causal particular and the constructed general character.



Contrast with Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology)		
Issue	FACT: Buddhist pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge) school	FACT: Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology)
Number of pramāṇas (plural form: means of valid knowledge)	FACT: Two: perception and inference	FACT: Four: perception, inference, comparison, testimony
Testimony	FACT: reducible to inference from reliable signs / speaker-function	FACT: independent pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge)
Universals	FACT: conceptual constructions	FACT: real universals inhering in particulars



9A.2 Svalakṣaṇa (unique momentary particular) and sāmānyalakṣaṇa (conceptually constructed general character)		
Feature	FACT: Svalakṣaṇa (unique momentary particular)	FACT: Sāmānyalakṣaṇa (conceptually constructed general character)
Ontological status	FACT: paramārtha-sat (ultimately real) (ultimately real)	FACT: saṃvṛti-sat (conventionally real) (conventionally real)
Temporal status	FACT: momentary	CAUTION: enduring only as a construct
Cognition	FACT: non-conceptual perception	FACT: conceptual inference / judgment
Language	FACT: ineffable as a unique particular	FACT: expressible and shareable
Causal role	FACT: causally efficient	CAUTION: causally inert as a universal construct



- Distinction**
- FACT: The **svalakṣaṇa** is unique, momentary, causally efficient, ineffable and non-conceptual.

- FACT: The **sāmānyalakṣaṇa** is shareable, expressible and stable only as a conceptual construction.
- CAUTION: This is why Buddhist realism about momentary particulars can coexist with nominalism about universals.



9A.3 Perception as **kalpanāpoḍha** (free from conceptual construction) and **abhrānta** (non-erroneous)



Statement

- FACT: Dignāga defines perception as **kalpanāpoḍha** (free from conceptual construction).
- FACT: Dharmakīrti adds **abhrānta** (non-erroneous), so perception is non-conceptual and non-mistaken.



Why the addition matters

- FACT: Mere vivid presentation is not enough for valid perception.
- FACT: Illusions such as a double moon or the circle produced by a whirling firebrand can be vivid while still mistaken.
- CAUTION: Dharmakīrti's addition protects Buddhist epistemology from counting every non-conceptual appearance as valid knowledge.



Fourfold division of perception

Type	FACT: Meaning	CAUTION: Philosophical point
indriya-pratyakṣa (sense perception)	FACT: sense perception	CAUTION: non-conceptual contact with the particular through sense-faculty
mānasa-pratyakṣa (mental perception)	FACT: mental perception	CAUTION: immediate mental awareness following sensory presentation
svasaṃvedana (reflexive self-awareness of cognition)	FACT: self-awareness of cognition	CAUTION: cognition manifests itself without a second knower
yogi-pratyakṣa (yogic perception)	FACT: yogic perception	CAUTION: disciplined direct insight into subtle truths relevant to liberation

- CAUTION: **Svasaṃvedana** connects Buddhist epistemology with Yogācāra idealism because cognition is treated as self-revealing; this is why Nyāya attacks it as collapsing object, cognition and knower.



9A.4 Apoha (exclusion of what is other) theory of meaning and universals



Statement

- FACT: **Apoha** (exclusion) says a general term does not denote a real universal (**jāti**) inhering in particulars.

- FACT: A word functions through **anya-apoha** (exclusion of the other): “cow” means “not-non-cow”.



Argument

- FACT: Only unique particulars are ultimately real.
- FACT: Words and concepts are general.
- FACT: If generality were real, one would need real universals; but universals are not perceived and produce the Nyāya problems of inherence and location.
- FACT: Therefore generality must be constructed negatively through exclusion.



Presupposition

- CAUTION: Apoha presupposes that a negative / differential function can do the work usually assigned to a positive shared property.



Objection — Kumārila Bhaṭṭa and Uddyotakara

- FACT: The exclusion seems circular: to exclude non-cows one must already know what a cow is.
- FACT: A merely negative content seems unable to explain the positive determinate cognition “cow”.
- FACT: It also seems unable to explain the felt similarity among cows.



Reply — Dharmakīrti's line

- FACT: Similarity is grounded not in a shared universal but in a shared causal capacity.
- FACT: Many distinct particulars produce the same effect: the same conceptual judgment and the same successful practical activity.
- FACT: Apoha is a conceptual construct erected upon that causal convergence, not upon a prior grasp of a real universal.
- CAUTION: The circularity objection retains residual force; many critics hold that the Buddhist reply does not fully explain positive determination.



9A.5 Arthakriyākāritva (capacity to perform a causal function) as the criterion of the real



Statement

- FACT: **Sat = arthakriyā-samartha**: to be real is to be capable of producing an effect.

• FACT: This criterion ranks the **svalakṣaṇa** as ultimately real and the **sāmānyalakṣaṇa** as conventional.



Argument connecting epistemology to kṣaṇikavāda (doctrine of momentariness)

- FACT: To be real is to be causally efficacious.
- FACT: Causal efficacy must occur either successively or simultaneously.
- FACT: A permanent entity can do neither coherently: if it produces everything at once, nothing remains for later moments; if it produces successively, it changes; if it needs auxiliary conditions, the decisive efficacy lies in the changing conditions.
- FACT: Therefore whatever is real is momentary — **yat sat tat kṣaṇikam**.



Exam payoff

• CAUTION: This is the clean bridge from pramāṇa theory to ontology: what perception ultimately presents is the momentary causally efficient particular; what inference and language manage is the conventional general construction.



9A.6 Pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge) and pramāṇaphala (result of valid cognition)



Statement

- FACT: Dignāga's distinctive thesis is that **pramāṇa** (instrument of knowledge) and **pramāṇaphala** (result of knowledge) are not two ultimately different things.
- FACT: The resultant cognition — the determination of the object and the self-awareness of cognition — is non-different from the cognitive event that functions as pramāṇa.



Argument

- FACT: On a momentary and non-substantialist ontology, there is no enduring agent-instrument-result triad.
- FACT: The analysis into **karaṇa** (instrument) and **phala** (result) is a conceptual overlay on one momentary cognitive event.
- CAUTION: This shows that Buddhist epistemology is internally driven by **anātman** and **kṣaṇikavāda**, not by free-standing formal logic.



Contrast with Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology)

Factor	FACT: Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology)	FACT: Buddhist pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge) school
pramātṛ (knower) (knower)	FACT: real enduring subject	CAUTION: constructed stream, not ultimate self

Factor	FACT: Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology)	FACT: Buddhist pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge) school
pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge) (instrument)	FACT: distinct means	FACT: non-different from cognition as event
prameya (object)	FACT: independently knowable object	FACT: ultimately svalakṣaṇa (unique momentary particular); conventionally constructed object
pramiti / pramāṇaphala (result of valid cognition) (result)	FACT: distinct resultant knowledge	FACT: not ultimately separate from pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge)



9B. AVYĀKATA (Pali term for an undeclared question) / AVYĀKṚTA (undeclared or unanswered metaphysical question) QUESTIONS — PRAGMATIC SILENCE



9B.1 The undeclared questions

- FACT: **Avyākata** / **avyākṛta** (undeclared / unanswered) questions are questions the Buddha declines to answer in the expected metaphysical format.
- FACT: They include whether the world is eternal or not eternal, finite or infinite; whether the **jīva** (life-principle / self) is the same as or different from the body; and whether the **Tathāgata** exists after death, does not exist, both, or neither.

AVYĀKṚTA (undeclared or unanswered metaphysical question) CLUSTER
World: eternal? not eternal? finite? infinite?
Self/body: jīva (living soul or conscious being) same as body? different from body?
Tathāgata (the Thus-Gone or Thus-Come Buddha) after death: exists? does not exist? both? neither?



9B.2 Why the Buddha declined



Statement

- FACT: The refusal is not a lack of doctrine; it is a disciplined refusal to answer malformed or soteriologically useless questions.



Argument

- FACT: The questions are **na arthasaṃhita** (not conducive to the goal / not connected with welfare and liberation).
- FACT: The arrow parable in the **Cūḷamālukya** teaching compares the metaphysical questioner to a man shot with a poisoned arrow who refuses treatment until he learns the archer's caste, name, bow-type and arrow-fletching; he dies before treatment.
- FACT: The questions rest on a false presupposition: they assume a substantial self or substantial world about which the alternatives can be predicated.
- CAUTION: The structure resembles the loaded question "Have you stopped beating your wife?"; any direct answer concedes the presupposition.
- FACT: Conditioned cognition cannot settle what is framed beyond the conditions of meaningful experience and liberation-oriented practice.



9B.3 Fire-going-out simile

- FACT: For the Tathāgata-after-death question, early Buddhist teaching uses the fire-going-out simile: when a fire has gone out, it cannot be said to have gone east, west, north or south.
- CAUTION: The point is not that a hidden self travels elsewhere; the categories of directional predication no longer apply once the sustaining conditions have ceased.



9B.4 Three readings of the silence

Reading	Claim	Strength	Limit
QUESTION: Agnostic	QUESTION: The Buddha did not know, or the matter is unknowable.	CAUTION: Explains non-answering simply.	CAUTION: Fits poorly with the strong positive diagnosis of suffering and cessation.
FACT: Pragmatic-therapeutic	FACT: The questions are useless for liberation.	FACT: Best fits the arrow parable's stated reason.	CAUTION: May understate the logical problem in the questions.
CAUTION: Logical-semantic	CAUTION: The questions are malformed because their presupposition of substantial self/world fails.	CAUTION: Best fits anātman (no permanent self) and dependent origination.	QUESTION: Not always explicitly formulated as a formal semantic theory in early sources.

- QUESTION: The tradition does not settle the issue in a single uncontested interpretation.
- CAUTION: For UPSC, combine the second and third readings: the questions are both therapeutically useless and presuppositionally defective.



9B.5 Objection and reply



Objection — realist / metaphysical critic

- FACT: Silence looks like evasion and leaves Buddhism metaphysically indeterminate.



Reply — Buddhist middle way

- FACT: The Buddha's positive teaching is precisely what he declared: Four Noble Truths, dependent origination, path and cessation.
- FACT: The middle way avoids both **śāśvatavāda** (eternalism) and **ucchedavāda** (annihilationism).
- FACT: Answering the avyākṛta questions in any of the four corners would concede the grammar of one of those extremes.
- CAUTION: Therefore silence is not emptiness of teaching; it is refusal to let the wrong question control the answer.



Exam route

- For *pramāṇa* questions, compare Buddhist two-*pramāṇa* theory with Nyāya's fourfold scheme.
- Define *kalpanāpoḍha* and explain why later Buddhists add non-erroneousness.
- In *apoha*, present the economy gained and the positive-content objection.
- Use pragmatic silence only where relevant; do not turn it into a blanket ban on philosophy.



Rapid recall

- Two *pramāṇas*: perception and inference.
- Perception is non-conceptual and non-erroneous.
- Particulars are ultimately causally real; universals are conceptual.
- *Apoha*: exclusion of the other.
- *Avyākata*: questions left undeclared because they do not conduce to liberation.



Plain-language visual - the complete Buddhist answer spine

DEPENDENT ORIGATION
|
IMPERMANENCE / MOMENTARINESS
|
NO PERMANENT SELF
|
CAUSAL CONTINUITY OF KARMA (action and its morally consequential residue)
|
CESSATION OF SUFFERING

In simple words: answer Buddhism as a connected process philosophy. Begin with conditions, derive change and no-self, explain continuity, and end with liberation.

Marks	Minimum structure
10	Define -> derive -> distinction -> significance
15	Doctrine -> example -> objection/reply -> verdict
20	Full causal chain -> school comparison -> dialectic -> assessment

Memory line: no substance is required if conditioned continuity can explain arising, responsibility and cessation.



9C. PRESUPPOSITION LEDGER

Doctrine	Presupposition	What collapses if denied
FACT: Pratītyasamutpāda (dependent origination)	CAUTION: Explanation must proceed through conditions rather than a static first substance.	CAUTION: The Four Noble Truths lose their causal grammar; suffering becomes fate or mystery.
FACT: Kṣaṇikavāda (doctrine of momentariness)	CAUTION: Whatever is conditioned and causally efficient cannot remain numerically permanent.	CAUTION: Buddhist critique of substance weakens; Nyāya-style endurance becomes possible.
FACT: Nairātmyavāda (doctrine of no permanent self)	CAUTION: Exhaustive analysis of experience finds aggregates and processes, not an owner behind them.	CAUTION: Karma (action and its morally consequential residue) and nirvāṇa (cessation of craving and conditioned suffering) must be reinterpreted through an ātman (enduring self or soul), which Buddhism (Buddha's path for understanding and ending suffering) refuses.
FACT: Arthakriyākāritva (capacity to perform a causal function)	CAUTION: Reality is measured by effect-producing capacity, not by inert self-identity.	CAUTION: Momentariness loses its strongest logical bridge from epistemology to ontology.
FACT: Apoha (exclusion of what is other)	CAUTION: Generality can be explained by exclusion and causal convergence without real universals.	CAUTION: Nyāya-Mīmāṃsā universals regain explanatory force.
FACT: Two truths	CAUTION: Conventional functioning and ultimate analysis answer different questions.	CAUTION: Madhyamaka appears either nihilist or secretly realist.
FACT: Śūnyatā (emptiness of independent intrinsic nature)	CAUTION: Whatever is dependently arisen lacks svabhāva (intrinsic own-nature).	CAUTION: Dependent origination remains a mere causal theory and does not become anti-essentialist.
FACT: Nirvāṇa (cessation of craving and conditioned suffering)	CAUTION: Bondage is a conditioned process; cessation is possible without a liberated soul-substance.	CAUTION: No-self and liberation appear inconsistent.



9D. PŪRVAPAKṢA (opponent's prima-facie position)–SIDDHĀNTA (established conclusion) LEDGER			
Objector (named)	Objection	Buddhist reply (school / thinker)	Residual force CAUTION:
FACT: Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology) — Vātsyāyana / Uddyotakara / Udayana	FACT: Recognition, memory and moral desert require an enduring self.	FACT: Sautrāntika (Buddhist representational-realist school)/Yogācāra (Buddhist consciousness-only school): santāna (causal continuum or stream) , sādrśya (similarity) , flame/river analogies; Yogācāra (Buddhist consciousness-only school) adds ālaya-vijñāna (store-consciousness) and bīja (causal seed or latent potency) .	CAUTION: A series may not “own” memories unless something owns the series.
FACT: Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology) realist	FACT: A permanent substance can act when auxiliaries are present.	FACT: Dharmakīrti line: sahakāri-anapekṣā (independence from auxiliary causes) / kramayaugapadya dilemma; changing conditions do the real work.	CAUTION: Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology)'s substance-quality model remains intuitively powerful.
FACT: Kumārila Bhaṭṭa	FACT: Self is required for duty, memory and pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge); universals are required for word-meaning.	FACT: Dignāga/Dharmakīrti: momentary cognitions plus apoha (exclusion of what is other) explain self and generality conventionally.	CAUTION: Apoha (exclusion of what is other)'s positive-determination problem persists.

Objector (named)	Objection	Buddhist reply (school / thinker)	Residual force CAUTION:
FACT: Uddyotakara	FACT: Apoha (exclusion of what is other) is circular: to exclude non-cows one must already know cow.	FACT: Dharmakīrti: exclusion is grounded in causal convergence and successful activity, not a prior universal.	CAUTION: The circularity charge is not fully dissolved for many critics.
FACT: Śaṃkara / Advaita	FACT: Momentariness makes bondage/liberation and unity of knower unintelligible; śūnyatā (emptiness of independent intrinsic nature) presupposes witnessing consciousness.	FACT: Madhyamaka/Yogācāra (Buddhist consciousness-only school) replies through two truths and self-revealing cognition without ātman (enduring self or soul).	CAUTION: Unity of experience remains the strongest Advaitic pressure point.
FACT: Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology) / modern realist	FACT: Catuskoṭi (four-cornered logical analysis) denial is self-contradictory or says nothing.	FACT: Nāgārjuna: non-implicative negation; empty words cure empty reification; no independent thesis.	CAUTION: Prāsaṅgika (Mādhyamika method relying on reductio) vs Svātantrika (Mādhyamika method using autonomous syllogisms) dispute shows internal unease.
FACT: Puggalavāda (Buddhist personalist school) / Vātsīputrīya foil	FACT: A person neither identical with nor different from skandhas (five aggregates constituting the person-process) is needed for continuity.	FACT: Mainstream Buddhism (Buddha's path for understanding and ending suffering): this risks reintroducing a disguised self; continuity is conventional designation on aggregates.	CAUTION: The pressure to preserve agency explains why the foil arose.
FACT: Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school) materialist	FACT: Reject self beyond body and deny post-mortem continuity.	FACT: Buddhism (Buddha's path for understanding and ending suffering) rejects permanent self but preserves karmic causal continuity beyond gross-body reduction.	CAUTION: Requires accepting causal continuity not directly reducible to perception.



9E. INTER-SCHOOL POSITIONING							
School	Pramāṇas (plural form: means of valid knowledge)	Ontology of self	Permanence / change	Causation	Universals	Scripture	Liberation
FACT: Buddhism (Buddha's path for understanding and ending suffering)	FACT: Dignāga-Dharmakīrti: two, perception and inference	FACT: no permanent ātman (enduring self or soul); person is aggregate / stream	FACT: conditioned reals are momentary	FACT: dependent origination	FACT: apoha (exclusion of what is other); no real jāti (birth)	FACT: Buddha-word valued, but not Vedic infallibility	FACT: cessation of ignorance, craving and duḥkha-process
FACT: Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika (combined realist traditions of logic and categories)	FACT: usually four in classical Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology)	FACT: enduring self-substance	FACT: substances endure through changing qualities	FACT: ārambhavāda-style production and theistic order in later Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology)	FACT: real universals	FACT: testimony as pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge), Veda accepted	FACT: true knowledge of self and categories, cessation of suffering

School	Pramāṇas (plural form: means of valid knowledge)	Ontology of self	Permanence / change	Causation	Universals	Scripture	Liberation
FACT: Sāṃkhya-Yoga (paired traditions of dualist enumeration and disciplined practice)	FACT: perception, inference and reliable testimony	FACT: many puruṣas (plural form: person or conscious principle)	FACT: puruṣa (person or conscious principle) permanent; prakṛti (primordial material nature) transforms	FACT: satkāryavāda (doctrine that the effect pre-exists in its cause) / pariṇāma (real transformation)	CAUTION: less central than tattva structure	FACT: scripture accepted with reasoning	FACT: kaivalya, isolation of puruṣa (person or conscious principle) from prakṛti (primordial material nature)
FACT: Jainism	FACT: multiple pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge)/naya approaches	FACT: real jīva (living soul or conscious being), intrinsically conscious	FACT: substance persists with changing modes	FACT: anekāntavāda and pariṇāmic (undergoing real transformation) change	FACT: real common features within many-sided realism	FACT: Jaina āgama (authoritative teaching or scripture) authority	FACT: release of jīva (living soul or conscious being) from karmic matter
FACT: Mīmāṃsā (Vedic exegesis school)	FACT: expands pramāṇas (plural form: means of valid knowledge); Kumāṛila accepts several including arthāpatti (postulation or presumption) and anupalabdhi (non-cognition used to know absence)	FACT: enduring self as agent/enjoyer	FACT: enduring subject and real ritual order	FACT: ritual efficacy and apūrva (unseen ritual potency)	FACT: real universals	FACT: Veda intrinsically authoritative	FACT: often framed through dharma (doctrine, duty or constitutive factor, as context requires) and cessation of obstacles, varies by sub-school
FACT: Cārvāka (Indian materialist and perception-centred school)	FACT: perception alone	FACT: self identified with body / consciousness as bodily product	FACT: material elements persist; no rebirth-continuity	FACT: material causation only	CAUTION: rejects metaphysical universals beyond perception	FACT: rejects Veda	FACT: no mokṣa (liberation) beyond worldly well-being
FACT: Advaita Vedānta (Upaniṣad-based end-of-the-Veda tradition)	FACT: six in developed Advaita	FACT: ātman (enduring self or soul) = Brahman, self-luminous	FACT: Brahman permanent; world ultimately mithyā (false or illusory)	FACT: vivarta / appearance	CAUTION: empirical universals within māyā (appearance or illusion)	FACT: Upaniṣadic (relating to the philosophical Upaniṣads) revelation central	FACT: knowledge of Brahman



9E.1 Buddhism (Buddha's path for understanding and ending suffering) vs Jainism — high-yield distinction

- FACT: Both are non-Vedic śramaṇa traditions and both reject a creator God as necessary for liberation.
- FACT: Jainism affirms **anekāntavāda** (many-sidedness): a substance can be permanent in substance and changing in modes.
- FACT: Buddhism denies substance: what looks like persistence is a conditioned series without an underlying dravya.
- FACT: The Jaina **jīva** is real and omniscient by nature when freed from karmic obstruction; the Buddhist self is a construct designated on skandhas.
- CAUTION: Trap to avoid: do not say both deny the soul. Buddhism denies ātman; Jainism strongly affirms jīva.



9E.2 Buddhism (Buddha's path for understanding and ending suffering) vs Advaita — avoid the “crypto-Advaita” trap

- FACT: Both deny that ordinary world-experience is ultimately real in the naive realist sense.
- FACT: Advaita's ultimate is positive, self-luminous **Brahman / ātman**.
- FACT: Madhyamaka **śūnyatā** is absence of **svabhāva**, not a hidden substrate.
- FACT: Advaita sublates world into Brahman; Madhyamaka refuses to replace empty phenomena with a metaphysical ground.
- CAUTION: Trap to refute: “Buddhist emptiness is just Advaita Brahman under another name.” The Buddhist case is anti-substantialist; Advaita is absolute-substantialist.



9F. CONTROLLED WESTERN COMPARISON

Western comparison	Point of contact	Disanalogy
FACT: Hume's bundle theory vs anātman (no permanent self)	FACT: Both deny a substantial self on broadly empiricist grounds.	CAUTION: Hume has no karmic continuity, no nirvāṇa-soteriology (theory of liberation through nirvāṇa) and treats self as imagination's fiction; Buddhism (Buddha's path for understanding and ending suffering) has a morally weighted causal series.
FACT: Heraclitus' flux vs kṣaṇikavāda (doctrine of momentariness)	FACT: Both stress universal change.	CAUTION: Heraclitus retains logos as ordering principle; Buddhist momentariness is tied to dependent origination and causal efficacy.
FACT: Whitehead's process thought vs momentary dharmas (plural form: doctrine, duty or constitutive factor, as context requires)	FACT: Both treat reality as event/process rather than inert substance.	CAUTION: Whitehead's metaphysical scheme is not the Buddhist no-self path and has no apoha (exclusion of what is other) or nirvāṇa (cessation of craving and conditioned suffering) framework.
FACT: Nāgārjuna's catuṣkoṭi (four-cornered logical analysis) vs Kant's antinomies	FACT: Both show reason generating opposed metaphysical conclusions.	CAUTION: Kant preserves the phenomenal object and limits categories; Nāgārjuna targets svabhāva (intrinsic own-nature) itself through emptiness.
FACT: Wittgenstein's therapeutic philosophy vs Buddha's silence	FACT: Both dissolve misleading questions rather than answer them on their own terms.	CAUTION: The Buddha's therapy is soteriological and rooted in duḥkha (suffering or unsatisfactoriness), karma (action and its morally consequential residue) and liberation.

Western comparison	Point of contact	Disanalogy
FACT: Ockham's nominalism vs apoha (exclusion of what is other)	FACT: Both deny real universals.	CAUTION: Apoha (exclusion of what is other)'s negative-exclusion mechanism and karmic-epistemic background have no exact Ockhamite counterpart; Ockham retains enduring individuals.

• **CAUTION: Rubric:** Western parallels are illustrative only; they must never replace the Indian argument and belong in at most one or two lines after the Buddhist case is complete.



9G. DIRECTIVE DECODER

Directive	What the examiner is testing	Structural move for a Buddhism (Buddha's path for understanding and ending suffering) answer	Closing verdict
Discuss	FACT: balanced exposition of doctrine and significance	CAUTION: define -> explain argument -> add school nuance -> conclude	CAUTION: "Thus the doctrine is central because..."
Examine	FACT: internal logic and assumptions	CAUTION: state thesis -> reconstruct reasoning -> expose presupposition	CAUTION: "It stands if its presupposition about ... is accepted."
Critically examine	FACT: doctrine plus objections/replies	CAUTION: doctrine -> named objection -> Buddhist reply -> residual force	CAUTION: "Strong as soteriology, debated as metaphysics."
Analyse	FACT: break doctrine into components	CAUTION: divide into causation, self, moment, liberation, epistemology	CAUTION: "The components converge on anti-substantialism."
Evaluate	FACT: final judgment on adequacy	CAUTION: strengths -> weaknesses -> contested point -> verdict	CAUTION: "Adequate for ..., weaker against ..."
Compare	FACT: similarity and difference across schools	CAUTION: use a table; then add one decisive contrast	CAUTION: "Similarity is formal; difference is doctrinal."
Distinguish	FACT: precise separation of close terms	CAUTION: two-column definitions, criteria and example	CAUTION: "Confusing them causes the standard UPSC trap."
Elucidate	FACT: clarify with examples	CAUTION: statement -> example -> doctrinal consequence	CAUTION: "The example shows the doctrine's exact sense."

Directive	What the examiner is testing	Structural move for a Buddhism (Buddha's path for understanding and ending suffering) answer	Closing verdict
Comment	FACT: interpret a quotation / claim	CAUTION: unpack claim -> support -> qualify -> conclude	CAUTION: "The claim is acceptable if read as ... not as ..."
Bring out	FACT: make an implicit relation explicit	CAUTION: show link, e.g. pratīyasamutpāda (dependent origination) -> kṣaṇikavāda (doctrine of momentariness) -> nairātmya (absence of a permanent self)	CAUTION: "The relation is logical, not merely historical."
Do you agree?	FACT: reasoned position	CAUTION: partial agreement -> objection -> defended verdict	CAUTION: "I agree in the conventional/ultimate sense specified above."



9H. GRADED VERDICT ON BUDDHISM (Buddha's path for understanding and ending suffering)



9H.1 What is strong

- FACT: Buddhism gives a powerful process-based account of suffering, causation and liberation through **pratītyasamutpāda**.
- FACT: It avoids both eternalism and annihilationism by using causal continuity without an eternal self.
- FACT: Kṣāṇikavāda is supported by a sharp causal-efficacy argument, especially in Dharmakīrti's pramāṇa framework.
- FACT: Madhyamaka's two truths allow it to deny intrinsic nature without abolishing ordinary practice.

**9H.2 What is weak**

- CAUTION: The denial of a persisting subject makes memory, recognition and moral desert philosophically difficult.
- CAUTION: Apoha explains universals economically but struggles to account for positive determinate cognition.
- CAUTION: Catuṣkoṭi and “no thesis” replies can look self-referentially unstable unless the non-implicative-negation nuance is clearly stated.

**9H.3 What is genuinely contested**

- QUESTION: Whether **svasaṃvedana** proves self-awareness or merely reifies cognition is debated between Buddhist epistemologists and Nyāya.
- QUESTION: Whether Madhyamaka's empty statements avoid self-refutation is debated both internally and by opponents.
- QUESTION: Whether a causal series is sufficient for moral responsibility without an owner remains the core cross-school dispute.

**9H.4 Ready one-line verdicts**

- CAUTION: **10 marks:** Buddhism replaces substance with conditioned process: this makes suffering removable, but raises the problem of continuity without self.
- CAUTION: **15 marks:** Its doctrines of dependent origination, momentariness and no-self form a coherent anti-substantialist system, though Nyāya and Vedānta press hard on memory, agency and liberation.
- CAUTION: **20 marks:** Buddhism is strongest as a therapeutic and causal philosophy of liberation; its deepest unresolved issue is whether causal continuity and two truths can fully replace the metaphysical work done by self, substance and universals in rival systems.

**10. PYQ ROUTING (2018–2025)**

CAUTION: Corpus signal: 13 primary-owned question-parts out of 112. The local Paper I corpus is continuous from 2018 through 2025. Cross-links do not create duplicate ownership.

Year	Question	Marks	Exact demand
2018	Q5(b)	10 marks	How do the Mādhyamika (Buddhist middle-way emptiness school) Buddhists apply the notion of Pratītyasamutpāda (dependent origination) to establish their doctrine of Śūnyatā (emptiness of independent intrinsic nature)? Discuss.
2018	Q6(b)	15 marks	Is it consistent for the Buddhists to admit the theory of Nairātmyavāda (doctrine of no permanent self) and the doctrine of Nirvāṇa (cessation of craving and conditioned suffering) simultaneously? Give reasons in favour of your answer.
2019	Q5(b)	10 marks	How do the Yogācāra (Buddhist consciousness-only school) Buddhists deny the existence of the external world? Discuss.
2019	Q7(c)	15 marks	What is Pratītyasamutpāda (dependent origination)? How do the Buddhists apply this concept to prove that everything is momentary?
2020	Q6(a)	20 marks	How is Kṣaṇikavāda (doctrine of momentariness) a logical derivative of Pratītyasamutpāda (dependent origination) in Buddhism (Buddha's path for understanding and ending suffering)? Explain.
2020	Q7(b)	15 marks	How does Buddhism (Buddha's path for understanding and ending suffering) explain Self in terms of Pañcaskandhas (five aggregates)? What is Liberation for Buddhism (Buddha's path for understanding and ending suffering) if there is no Soul?
2021	Q5(d)	10 marks	Distinguish between pudgala-nairātmyavāda (doctrine of no-self of the person) and dharma-nairātmyavāda (doctrine that phenomena lack intrinsic self-nature) with reference to Buddhist Philosophy.
2021	Q7(b)	15 marks	If everything is momentary then how do the Buddhists explain the problem of memory and personal identity? Critically discuss.
Year	Question	Marks	Exact demand
2022	Q6(a)	20 marks	How compatible is Buddhist theory of momentariness with their theory of Karma (action and its morally consequential residue)? In this regard how do Buddhists respond to objections raised by their opponents? Critically discuss.
2022	Q7(b)	15 marks	Explain Buddhist concept of Triratna (three jewels: Buddha, Dharma and Sangha) and their internal relation. Critically examine the consistency of Triratnas (plural form: three jewels: Buddha, Dharma and Sangha) with the Buddhist concept of No-soul (Nairātmyavāda (doctrine of no permanent self)).
2023	Q8(a)	20 marks	"Ignorance of dependent origination is suffering while its knowledge is cessation of suffering." Present an account of Buddhist soteriology in the light of above statement.
2024	Q6(b)	15 marks	How do the two schools of Buddhism (Buddha's path for understanding and ending suffering) arrive at two opposed conclusions, namely "everything is void" and "everything is real" from the same doctrine of Pratītyasamutpāda (dependent origination)? Answer with arguments.
2025	Q8(c)	15 marks	Is Buddhist notion of Nirvāṇa (cessation of craving and conditioned suffering) in consonance with their conception of Kṣaṇikavāda (doctrine of momentariness) (momentariness) and Nairātmyavāda (doctrine of no permanent self) (no-soul theory)? Critically discuss.

See the Indian Philosophy PYQ Bank, 2018–2025.



11. ANSWER ARCHITECTURE (10 / 15 / 20 marks)

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Final verdict: Buddhist philosophy replaces substantial identity with dependent continuity, but its success depends on explaining how causal efficacy, knowledge and liberation remain coherent without a permanent self or intrinsic essence.



11.1 For a 10-marker

Define the doctrine in one line.
 State the core argument in 3–4 crisp steps.
 Add one distinction (e.g. pudgala- vs dharma-nairātmya (no intrinsic self-nature in phenomena); realism vs emptiness).
 Close with one line of significance.

**11.2 For a 15-marker**

Intro: locate the issue in Buddhist soteriology.
 Body A: doctrine stated precisely.
 Body B: argument with one example.
 Body C: objection and Buddhist reply.
 Conclusion: show why the doctrine matters for duḥkha (suffering or unsatisfactoriness) / nirvāṇa (cessation of craving and conditioned suffering).

**11.3 For a 20-marker**

Frame: connect the question to the Four Noble Truths.
 Exposition: full doctrine with technical vocabulary.
 Analysis: derive the linked Buddhist claim (e.g. momentariness from dependent origination).
 Debate: contrast two schools or answer a major objection.
 Verdict: give a balanced philosophical assessment.

**12. LINK-OUTS**

- Nyaya-Vaisesika.md — contrast on self, causation, pramāṇa and God.
- Carvaka.md — contrast on self and rejection of transcendence.
- Jainism.md — compare continuity-through-change with Buddhist momentariness.
- ../_themes/Causation-across-schools.md — pratīyasamutpāda vs satkāryavāda vs ārambhavāda.
- ../_themes/Self-and-liberation-across-schools.md — anātman vs ātman accounts.
- ../PYQ-Indian-Philosophy-2018-2025.md — year-wise Indian Philosophy routing.
- ../paper-2/philosophy-of-religion/Proofs-for-God.md — cross-paper God debate.
- ../paper-2/philosophy-of-religion/Religion-without-God.md — Buddhism as a non-theistic religion.
- ../paper-2/philosophy-of-religion/Soul-Immortality-Rebirth.md — rebirth without immortal soul.



SOURCES

- *Majjhima Nikāya* and related early Buddhist formulations of dependent origination, used in substance where directly phrased.
- Nāgārjuna, *Mūlamadhyamakārikā*, especially the standard identification in substance of dependent origination and emptiness.
- Chatterjee & Datta, *An Introduction to Indian Philosophy*.
- C.D. Sharma, *A Critical Survey of Indian Philosophy*.
- S. Radhakrishnan, *Indian Philosophy*, Vol. I and II, where relevant to Buddhist schools.
- Standard expositions of *Milinda-pañha* for the chariot analogy, paraphrased where exact wording is uncertain.
- FACT: Dignāga and Dharmakīrti, standard pramāṇa-school doctrines of perception, inference, apoha and pramāṇaphala, paraphrased without verse-number claims.
- FACT: Early Buddhist discussions of the avyākata / avyākṛta questions and the Cūḷamālukya arrow parable, used in substance without invented citation numbering.
- FACT: Nāgārjuna, *Vigrahavyāvartanī*, for the no-thesis / self-referential defence, used in substance without verse-number claims.

**CURRENT LINKAGE - BUDDHIST HERITAGE AS CULTURAL DIPLOMACY**

FACT: Official fact: The High Commission of India in Colombo reported that India sent the Devnimori Buddha relics from Gujarat to the Gangaramaya Temple, Colombo, for public exposition from 4 to 10 February 2026. The official release described the initiative as cultural and spiritual engagement with Sri Lanka through shared Buddhist heritage.

CAUTION: Philosophy Optional use: This event does not prove any Buddhist doctrine. Use it only as a contemporary introduction or conclusion showing how a philosophical-religious tradition also functions as a civilizational language in diplomacy. Doctrinal answers must remain grounded in pratīyasamutpada, momentariness, no-self, the two truths, compassion, and the relevant school.

Source trail used for this package

- FACT: Repository owner: paper-1/indian/Buddhism.md.
- FACT: Chatterjee and Datta, local OCR edition, especially file pages 149-194: dependent origination, transience, no-self, and the four schools.
- FACT: C. D. Sharma, local OCR edition, especially file pages 67-81: early Buddhism, twelve links, momentariness, realist schools, and nirvana.
- FACT: Official High Commission of India, Colombo release on the Devnimori relic exposition, rechecked 18 August 2026.

**Exam route**

The complete corpus contains **13 primary-owned questions from 2018-2025**:

- Dependent origination and emptiness: 2018.

- Yogācāra external-world critique: 2019.
 - Momentariness derivation: 2019 and 2020.
 - No-self, aggregates and nirvāṇa: 2018, 2020, 2021 and 2025.
 - Memory and karma under momentariness: 2021 and 2022.
 - Triratna and no-self: 2022.
 - Soteriology through dependent origination: 2023.
 - Realism versus emptiness: 2024.
- The retained routing table, directive decoder and marks-wise frameworks below should be used before attempting the full solved practice.



Rapid recall - final master matrix	
Prompt	Recall spine
Causation	conditioned arising and cessation
Reality	causal efficacy; momentary particulars
Person	five aggregates and causal designation
Continuity	<i>santāna</i> (causal continuum or stream), seeds and store-consciousness
Schools	direct realism -> inferred realism -> cognition-only -> emptiness
Language	<i>apoha</i> (exclusion of what is other)
Liberation	cessation of the causes of suffering
Verdict	process without substance; continuity with an ownership burden



PART II - SOLVED PYQs, PRACTICE AND ANSWER TRAINING

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH — NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER



Layer-placement note

All Layer 3 material from the legacy complete session is retained here after practice. It should refine a core answer, not displace the printed syllabus.



Advanced derivation and school divergence

Dependent origination is not a search for the universe's first cause. It diagnoses the structure of conditioned becoming here and now. This avoids eternalism because no unchanged self grounds the process, and avoids annihilationism because causal continuity remains.

The doctrine supports different ontological conclusions. Mādhyamika argues that whatever depends on conditions lacks *svabhāva* and is therefore empty. Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika instead emphasise that causally functioning conditioned events are real. Their disagreement concerns ultimate status, not whether dependent arising occurs.

The strongest challenge is regress: if every event is conditioned, what explains the chain as a whole? The Buddhist reply is therapeutic and structural rather than foundational—the task is to identify and cease the conditions of suffering, not posit an unconditioned creator-substance.

**Advanced argument and Nyāya (school of logic and epistemology) pressure**

The causal-efficiency argument asks how a wholly permanent cause could produce effects at different times. If its complete power operates immediately, all effects should appear together; if it produces successively, its causal profile changes and it is not wholly permanent. Auxiliary conditions do not automatically save permanence: if they make the decisive difference, the unchanged cause appears redundant.

Nyāya's reply remains powerful. An enduring substance may act when the required conditions arrive, while recognition—"this is that"—memory and moral ownership seem to presuppose numerical identity. Buddhism answers with similarity, causal transmission, seeds and, in Yogācāra, *ālaya-vijñāna*.

The residual issue is ownership. A stream can transmit information and karmic effects, but critics ask what makes it *one person's* stream rather than merely a sequence externally described as one.

**Advanced compatibility problem**

The chariot analogy shows that a person is designated upon organised components and relations; no separate chariot-substance or person-substance must be added. Early Buddhism primarily denies *pudgala-ātman*, while Mahāyāna extends emptiness to dharmas themselves.

Karma without self avoids both strict identity and complete difference: the later recipient is neither numerically identical to nor causally disconnected from the earlier agent. This middle position preserves transmission but remains vulnerable to the moral-ownership objection.

Nirvāṇa is not the immortality of an ego and not the destruction of an eternal person. It is cessation of greed, hatred, delusion and the conditioned production of suffering. Theravāda may distinguish the unconditioned from momentary conditioned dharmas; Mādhyamika avoids reifying nirvāṇa as a separate substance by reading saṃsāra and nirvāṇa through emptiness.

**Advanced distinctions and anti-nihilist safeguards**

Yogācāra should not be equated casually with Advaita. Its *ālaya-vijñāna* is a conditioned stream carrying seeds, not an eternal Brahman or creator consciousness. The three natures distinguish imagined duality, dependent cognitive process and the perfected absence of that duality.

Mādhyamika's *catuṣkoṭi* is a dialectical test of reified alternatives, not a licence to assert contradictions. The two truths preserve conventional causation and practice while denying intrinsic nature ultimately. "Emptiness of emptiness" blocks the transformation of *śūnyatā* into a new Absolute.

Buddhist criticism of a creator stresses explanatory redundancy, the incompatibility of immutable agency with temporal action, and the moral problem of suffering. Dependent origination supplies a non-theistic causal alternative without claiming that events are uncaused.



Advanced dialectical verdict

Nyāya's recognition and memory objections target ownership rather than mere transmission. Buddhist stream theories explain how traces continue, but the critic asks who recognises or deserves. Mīmāṃsā adds a semantic challenge: *apoha* may explain exclusion but appears to presuppose positive similarity.

Advaita criticism presses the soteriological cost of emptiness and momentariness. The Buddhist response distinguishes conventional path and ultimate non-reification; liberation is transformation and cessation within the process, not discovery of an eternal witness.

Cārvāka and Buddhism both reject a transcendent self, but Cārvāka identifies the person with the conscious body while Buddhism analyses body and mind into a causal aggregate-stream. The disagreement is therefore material identity versus process ontology.

A balanced verdict concedes that Buddhism offers a sophisticated non-substantialist model while leaving a real philosophical burden concerning first-person unity and moral ownership.



Advanced control of terminology

Technical vocabulary should mark distinctions, not decorate prose. *Anitya* is general impermanence; *kṣaṇikavāda* is the radical scholastic claim of momentariness. *Śūnyatā* denies *svabhāva*, not conventional causation. *Nairātmyavāda* denies permanent selfhood, not the pragmatic designation of persons.

The restored doctrine material also prevents a narrow syllabus reading. Pañcaskandhas, liberation, Buddhist epistemology and the four schools explain how the three headline doctrines actually function.



Advanced epistemic and pragmatic issues

The two-pramāṇa theory aligns epistemology with momentariness: only the unique causally effective particular is ultimately real, while universals are conceptual. *Apoha* avoids eternal universals by explaining "cow" through exclusion of non-cows, but opponents ask how exclusion works without some positive basis of similarity.

The relation between *pramāṇa* and *pramāṇaphala* reflects a process model of cognition rather than Nyāya's sharply separated instrument and result. This is a high-value cross-school comparison.

The Buddha's silence on undeclared questions is pragmatic, not mere ignorance. The poisoned-arrow reasoning asks whether speculation conduces to cessation. The danger is anti-intellectualism; the defence is disciplined relevance. The silence rejects metaphysical fixation without denying that causal and ethical analysis is possible.



Advanced synthesis

Buddhism's greatest strength is the integration of metaphysics and therapy. Dependent origination explains why suffering arises and how it can cease; momentariness and no-self prevent reification; the schools then debate how much reality, consciousness or emptiness the process requires.

Its central philosophical risk is that causal continuity may not fully replace first-person unity, recognition and moral ownership. Madhyamaka adds a second risk: anti-essentialist language can look self-refuting unless the two truths and emptiness of emptiness are stated clearly.

The defensible verdict is neither "Buddhism denies reality" nor "Buddhism is modern science." It is a rigorous anti-substantialist and soteriological process philosophy whose internal variants range from realism to idealist analysis and radical emptiness.

□ **Current conceptual anchor:** the February 2026 Devnimori relic exposition in Colombo, officially documented by the High Commission of India, illustrates Buddhist heritage as cultural diplomacy. It is contextual evidence only, never proof of doctrine.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER RETRIEVAL



A. System identity

- Printed syllabus: schools of Buddhism; dependent origination; momentariness; no-self.
- Four Noble Truths provide the existential frame.
- Doctrine is diagnostic and soteriological, not merely speculative.
- Main school spectrum: Vaibhāṣika, Sautrāntika, Yogācāra and Mādhyamika.



B. Dependent origination

- “This being, that arises; this ceasing, that ceases.”
- Twelve links run from ignorance to ageing and death.
- It rejects both eternalism and annihilationism.
- Conditioned suffering is removable because its sustaining conditions can cease.



C. Derivation spine

- DEPENDENT ARISING
-> no independent self-grounding
-> impermanence
-> momentariness of the causally real
-> no permanent owner behind the aggregates
- Mādhyamika further derives emptiness of *svabhāva*.
 - Realist schools instead stress the reality of conditioned dharmas.



D. Momentariness

- *Arthakriyākāritva*: the real performs a causal function.

- A wholly permanent cause should act always or never.
- Successive causal action implies different moment-specific capacities.
- Apparent endurance is a causally connected *santāna*.



E. No-self

- The person is designated on five aggregates: form, feeling, perception, formations and consciousness.
- Person-no-self denies a permanent subject.
- Dharma-no-self denies intrinsic nature in phenomena.
- No-self removes grasping; it does not abolish causal continuity or conventional agency.



F. Karma (action and its morally consequential residue), memory and nirvāṇa (cessation of craving and conditioned suffering)

- Karma requires continuity, not numerical identity of substance.
- Memory tracks a causally connected stream, though ownership remains a pressure point.
- Nirvāṇa is cessation of ignorance, craving and suffering-producing conditions.
- No-self and nirvāṇa are compatible because liberation transforms a stream rather than frees an eternal soul.



G. Four schools

School	External world	Cognition	Signature
Vaibhāṣika (Buddhist direct-realist Abhidharma school)	real, directly perceived	direct realism	real dharmas (plural form: doctrine, duty or constitutive factor, as context requires)
Sautrāntika (Buddhist representational-realist school)	real, inferred	representational realism	momentary external causes
Yogācāra (Buddhist consciousness-only school)	not independently established	cognition-only	<i>viññaptimātratā</i> (cognition-only or representation-only)
Mādhyamika (Buddhist middle-way emptiness school)	conventionally functional	no intrinsic entities	<i>śūnyatā</i> (emptiness of independent intrinsic nature)



H. Yogācāra (Buddhist consciousness-only school)

- Dream and atom arguments challenge independently established external objects.
- *Ālayavijñāna* carries karmic seeds and explains ordered experience.
- Three natures: imagined, dependent and perfected.
- Mind-only is not arbitrary private fantasy; it is a structured causal account of cognition.



I. Mādhyamika (Buddhist middle-way emptiness school)

- What arises dependently lacks self-existent *svabhāva*.
- Emptiness is not non-being; conventional causation and language remain operative.
- Two truths: conventional and ultimate.
- Emptiness is itself empty and must not become a new Absolute.



J. Epistemology and silence

- Dignāga–Dharmakīrti recognize perception and inference.
- Perception grasps the unique particular; concepts work through exclusion (*apoha*).
- *Pramāṇaphala* links valid cognition and its result.
- Silence on *avyākṛta* questions is pragmatic: irrelevant speculation does not end suffering.



K. Criticism–reply grid

Pressure	Buddhist reply	Residual issue
no self, no responsibility	causal stream transmits consequences	moral ownership
momentariness blocks memory	later moments inherit traces	first-person identity
emptiness is nihilism	two truths preserve convention	self-reference
Yogācāra (Buddhist consciousness-only school) becomes solipsism	karmic seeds explain ordered experience	intersubjectivity
permanence can await auxiliaries	changed causal complex does the work	status of enduring powers



L. Final answer discipline

- Start from the exact doctrine and define the key Sanskrit term.
- Show the derivation rather than merely list conclusions.
- Distinguish causal continuity from substantial identity.
- Identify the school before attributing realism, mind-only or emptiness.
- State one serious objection and the strongest Buddhist reply.
- Preserve the difference between conventional reality and intrinsic nature.
- Conclude with a graded soteriological and philosophical verdict.

Final judgement: Buddhism tightly connects causation, metaphysics and liberation. Its strength is an anti-essentialist process account of suffering; its hardest problems concern identity, moral ownership, intersubjectivity and the non-nihilistic articulation of emptiness.

PYQ ROUTES, COMPARISON & ANSWER SPINE

Use: identify the directive -> state the thesis -> define the doctrine -> derive the mechanism -> present objection and reply -> compare only where demanded -> qualify the verdict. Full solved prose remains in the workbook.



VERIFIED PYQS — 13 COMPLETE SOLUTIONS



2018 · Q5(b) · 10 marks

Question: How do the Mādhyamika Buddhists apply the notion of Pratītyasamutpāda to establish their doctrine of Śūnyatā? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Why this earns marks



2018 · Q6(b) · 15 marks

Demand decoding

- Give reasons in favour while acknowledging the first-person identity objection.

The objection is immediate: if no self exists, nobody suffers, practises or attains liberation. The Buddhist reply invokes *santāna*, causal continuity. The later liberated stream is neither numerically identical with nor wholly unrelated to the earlier bound stream. Ethical discipline and meditative cultivation alter succeeding moments just as one flame conditions another without a single enduring flame-substance.

Why this earns marks

- States the strongest objection and offers a qualified verdict.



2019 · Q5(b) · 10 marks

Question: How do the Yogācāra Buddhists deny the existence of the external world? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Why this earns marks



2019 · Q7(c) · 15 marks

Demand decoding

- Include causal efficacy, apparent continuity and at least one objection.

Nyāya objects that a permanent substance can possess stable power and act when *sahakārin* auxiliaries arrive. The Buddhist reply asks whether those auxiliaries alter the cause. If they do, strict permanence is abandoned; if they do not, the delayed effect remains unexplained.

Why this earns marks

- Handles Nyāya's auxiliary-condition objection.



2020 · Q6(a) · 20 marks

Demand decoding

- Address continuity, objections and the Mādhyamika refinement.

Pratītyasamutpāda states that every conditioned phenomenon arises and ceases through a determinate complex of conditions. *Kṣaṇikavāda* radicalizes this into the thesis that every causally real conditioned entity exists for only a moment. The derivation proceeds through dependence, change and causal efficacy.

Second, causal production marks a difference between phases. A seed capable of sprouting under one complex and no longer functioning as that seed after germination cannot be strictly identical before and after causal action. The effect is novel because the operative causal phase perishes in giving rise to its successor.

Why this earns marks

- Engages Nyāya's named *sahakārin* reply.

- Concludes with a precise synthesis.



2020 · Q7(b) · 15 marks

Demand decoding

- Explain liberation positively and answer the “who is liberated?” objection.

The objection asks who receives the fruit if the practitioner constantly changes. Buddhism answers through *santāna*. The later liberated stream inherits the effects of earlier practice without being an unchanging substance. Causal continuity is sufficient for transformation just as education changes a child into an adult without requiring an immutable psychological core.

Why this earns marks

- Answers the agency/recipient objection with *santāna*.



2021 · Q5(d) · 10 marks

Demand decoding

Why this earns marks



2021 · Q7(b) · 15 marks

Question: If everything is momentary then how do the Buddhists explain the problem of memory and personal identity? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

- Evaluate Nyāya's first-person ownership objection.

Nyāya's *pratyabhijñā* and memory objection remains powerful. Cognitions such as “this is that” and “I saw this” seem to presuppose one enduring subject that unifies past and present. Mere resemblance can explain similar content but perhaps not first-person ownership. The Buddhist replies that the “I” is itself a concept generated within an integrated stream: direct causal inheritance, not metaphysical substance, grounds appropriation.

This reply successfully explains information transmission and practical identity, much as ordinary law follows a changing person through time. Yet if first-person unity is regarded as irreducible, *santāna* may seem descriptive rather than fully explanatory.

Why this earns marks



2022 · Q6(a) · 20 marks

Question: How compatible is Buddhist theory of momentariness with their theory of Karma? In this regard how do Buddhists respond to objections raised by their opponents? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

- Name classical objections and school-specific Buddhist mechanisms.
- Critically test whether causation is enough for moral ownership.

Nyāya, Mīmāṃsā and Vedānta press three related objections. First, *kṛtanāśa*: because the doer perishes, the deed and its desert are lost. Second, *akṛtābhyāgama*: a later, numerically different moment receives the fruit of an act it did not perform. Third, praise, blame, recognition and remorse appear to presuppose one owner across time.

The Buddhist reply rejects the exhaustive choice between absolute identity and absolute difference. The fruit occurs in the very continuum causally formed by the action, not in an unrelated stream. A child and adult are neither qualitatively unchanged nor morally unrelated; responsibility normally tracks continuity of body, intention, memory and causal history rather than an empirically inaccessible ātman.

The objection that a momentary cause cannot yield a remote result is answered by serial transmission. Each moment immediately conditions the next, carrying transformed potency until supporting conditions permit maturation. A seed need not remain numerically present in the fruit; its causal influence persists through the series.

Karma and momentariness are therefore compatible within Buddhist process ontology. The account is strong against the demand for numerical identity, but its reduction of moral ownership to causal inheritance remains open to realist criticism.

Why this earns marks

- Answers both delayed fruition and personal ownership objections.
- Critically tests whether *ālaya-vijñāna* becomes a quasi-self.
- Ends with a balanced verdict rather than a doctrinal assertion.

**2022 · Q7(b) · 15 marks**

Question: Explain Buddhist concept of Triratna and their internal relation. Critically examine the consistency of Triratnas with the Buddhist concept of No-soul (Nairātmyavāda).

Demand decoding

- Examine whether refuge, community and awakening require enduring selves.

The two truths deepen this reply. Conventionally, teachers, vows, institutions and agents operate; ultimately, none possesses independent self-nature. No-self therefore regulates the meaning of refuge: it is practical orientation and transformative dependence, not surrender by one immortal substance to another.

A critic may reply that continuity of doctrine and authority still requires stable bearers. The Buddhist response is that transmission needs reliable causal and institutional continuity, not numerical identity. Manuscripts, practices and lineages persist as changing but connected series.

Why this earns marks

- Addresses continuity of authority and ends with an integrative verdict.



2023 · Q8(a) · 20 marks

Demand decoding

Why this earns marks

- Makes the quotation the organizing thesis.



2024 · Q6(b) · 15 marks

Question: How do the two schools of Buddhism arrive at two opposed conclusions, namely “everything is void” and “everything is real” from the same doctrine of Pratītyasamutpāda? Answer with arguments.

Demand decoding

- Show how the same premise yields different conclusions.

Shared premise	Realist conclusion	Mādhyamika (Buddhist middle-way emptiness school) conclusion
phenomena arise through conditions	causal efficacy establishes conditioned reality	dependence disproves self-existence
permanent substance is rejected	momentary dharmas (plural form: doctrine, duty or constitutive factor, as context requires) remain ultimately real	even momentary dharmas (plural form: doctrine, duty or constitutive factor, as context requires) lack <i>svabhāva</i> (intrinsic own-nature)
ordinary causation works	because real particulars interact	because conventionally designated relations function

Why this earns marks

- Derives both conclusions from one premise.



2025 · Q8(c) · 15 marks

Question: Is Buddhist notion of Nirvāṇa in consonance with their conception of Kṣaṇikavāda (momentariness) and Nairātmyavāda (no-soul theory)? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

- Address conditioned/unconditioned and “who attains?” objections.

- Include a Mādhyamika qualification and a balanced verdict.

Why this earns marks



Original 1 · 10 marks

Demand decoding

Verdict: Pratītyasamutpāda is liberating precisely because it is causal. By explaining how suffering is made, it shows how suffering can be unmade.

Why this earns marks



Original 2 · 10 marks

Demand decoding

The main objection is that causal connection may not fully explain first-person ownership—why a later memory or karmic fruit is *mine*. Buddhism replies that “mine” is itself constructed within the integrated stream.

Verdict: Buddhist no-self is a revision of personal identity from substance to dependent process, not the elimination of practical personhood.

Why this earns marks



Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: Compare Vaibhāṣika, Sautrāntika, Yogācāra and Mādhyamaka as four answers to the problem of the object of knowledge.

Demand decoding

- Compare all four schools on one epistemic–ontological axis.
- Give strengths, pressures and a qualified verdict.

Verdict: The debate moves from “Which object is known?” to “Can knower or known be intrinsically grounded?” Mādhyamaka is the most radical answer, but it remains viable only if conventional truth genuinely supports knowledge and argument.

Why this earns marks

- Compares all four schools through a common matrix.
- Evaluates each position and reaches a qualified verdict.



Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: Does the Buddhist theory of Apoha successfully explain general words without admitting real universals? Discuss.

Demand decoding

- Present its mechanism, named objection and Buddhist reply.

The Buddhist reply distinguishes causal acquisition from philosophical analysis. Linguistic competence develops through practices of differentiation, not prior apprehension of a metaphysical universal. Mutual exclusions can generate a stable conceptual image, and practical success—not correspondence with an eternal entity—is the test of semantic adequacy.

Yet the objection is not fully dissolved. Apoha economically explains classification without realism about universals, but the positive phenomenology of meaning may be redescribed rather than completely derived from negation.

Verdict: Apoha is ontologically parsimonious and pragmatically powerful. Its weakness lies less in reference to particulars than in explaining how differential exclusion acquires the experienced positive unity of a concept.

Why this earns marks

- Names Kumāṛila and Uddyotakara's objections.
- Presents the Buddhist practice-and-exclusion reply.



Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: "Buddhist process ontology secures change more successfully than it secures moral responsibility." Critically examine.

Demand decoding

This answer defeats a crude objection. Ordinary responsibility already survives major bodily and psychological change. A mature adult may answer for a childhood promise because causal history, memory, intention and social continuity connect the phases. Numerical identity of an unobservable soul appears unnecessary.

The Buddhist reply is that desert supervenes on intentional causal inheritance within one stream. The "owner" adds no explanatory work unless its interaction with changing mental states is shown. Mādhyamaka further treats agent, act and fruit as conventionally dependent; morality needs stable practices, not ultimate substances.

Verdict: Buddhism explains change more naturally than substance theories because causal novelty is basic rather than derivative. Its account of responsibility is coherent and practically adequate, but less decisive: causal inheritance plausibly grounds accountability, yet the transition from succession to first-person moral ownership remains contested.

Why this earns marks

- Evaluates both change and responsibility rather than discussing karma alone.
- Ends with a measured, examiner-grade verdict.



Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: "Mādhyamaka avoids nihilism only by preserving the authority of conventional truth." Examine with reference to Pratītyasamutpāda, the two truths and the emptiness of emptiness.

Demand decoding

The two truths articulate this insight. At *saṃvṛti-satya*, persons deliberate, words refer, reasons support conclusions, karma bears fruit and the path ends suffering. At *paramārtha-satya*, analysis finds no independently existing agent, word, reason or dharma. Ultimate truth is not a second world behind convention; it is the absence of intrinsic nature in the conventional world.

The nihilist objection may persist: if conventional truth is itself empty, why trust it? Mādhyamaka replies that validity need not mean self-grounding. A map can guide without containing an intrinsic “map essence”; similarly, conventions are evaluated through coherence, dependence and practical success. The distinction between valid convention and hallucination remains internal to causal practices.

Realists such as Nyāya object that this position borrows logic and causation while denying the stable entities required for them. If every thesis is empty, the thesis of emptiness appears self-refuting. Mādhyamaka answers that argument does not require intrinsically existent premises; conventional relations of entailment suffice. The critique targets the opponent’s claim of self-existence without proposing a rival essence.

Verdict: Mādhyamaka avoids nihilism because emptiness and convention are mutually dependent: emptiness prevents reification, while convention preserves causation, rational assessment and liberation. The emptiness of emptiness completes the anti-essentialist logic, but the school’s success depends upon making conventional validity more than mere illusion.

Why this earns marks

- Frames the strongest nihilist and self-refutation objections.
- Gives a qualified verdict identifying the doctrine’s precise burden.

FINAL RAPID-RECALL SEQUENCE

01. 0. ONE-SCREEN MAP	02. 1. PRATĪTYASAMUTPĀDA (dependent origination) (Pratityasamutpada (dependent origination)) — DEPENDENT ORIGINATION
03. 2. KṢAṆIKAVĀDA (doctrine of momentariness) (Ksanikavada (doctrine of momentariness)) — DOCTRINE OF MOMENTARINESS	04. 3. NAIRĀTMYAVĀDA (doctrine of no permanent self) (Nairatmyavada (doctrine of no permanent self)) — NO-SELF DOCTRINE
05. 4. THE FOUR SCHOOLS OF BUDDHISM (Buddha's path for understanding and ending suffering)	06. 5. BUDDHIST ARGUMENTS AGAINST A CREATOR GOD
07. 6. INTER-THINKER / INTER-SCHOOL DEBATES	08. 7. CRITICISMS AND REPLIES — NAMED PŪRVAPAKṢA (opponent's prima-facie position)
09. 8. COMMON UPSC TRAPS	10. 9. KEYWORD & STATEMENT BANK
11. 9A. BUDDHIST EPISTEMOLOGY — THE PRAMĀṆA (means of valid knowledge) SCHOOL (Dignāga, Dharmakīrti)	12. 9B. AVYĀKĀTA (Pali term for an undeclared question) / AVYĀKṚTA (undeclared or unanswered metaphysical question) QUESTIONS — PRAGMATIC SILENCE
13. 9C. PRESUPPOSITION LEDGER	14. 9D. PŪRVAPAKṢA (opponent's prima-facie position)–SIDDHĀNTA (established conclusion) LEDGER